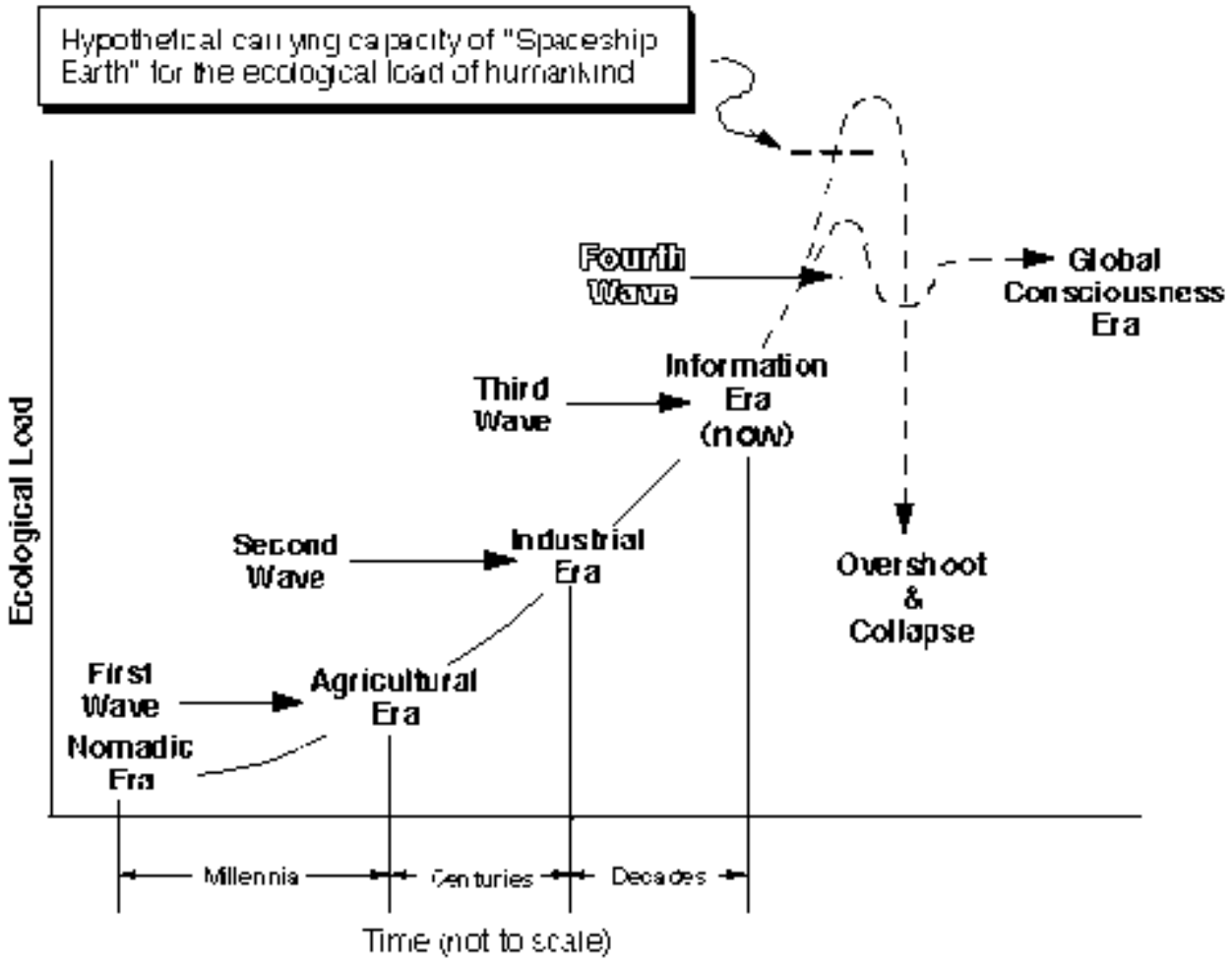


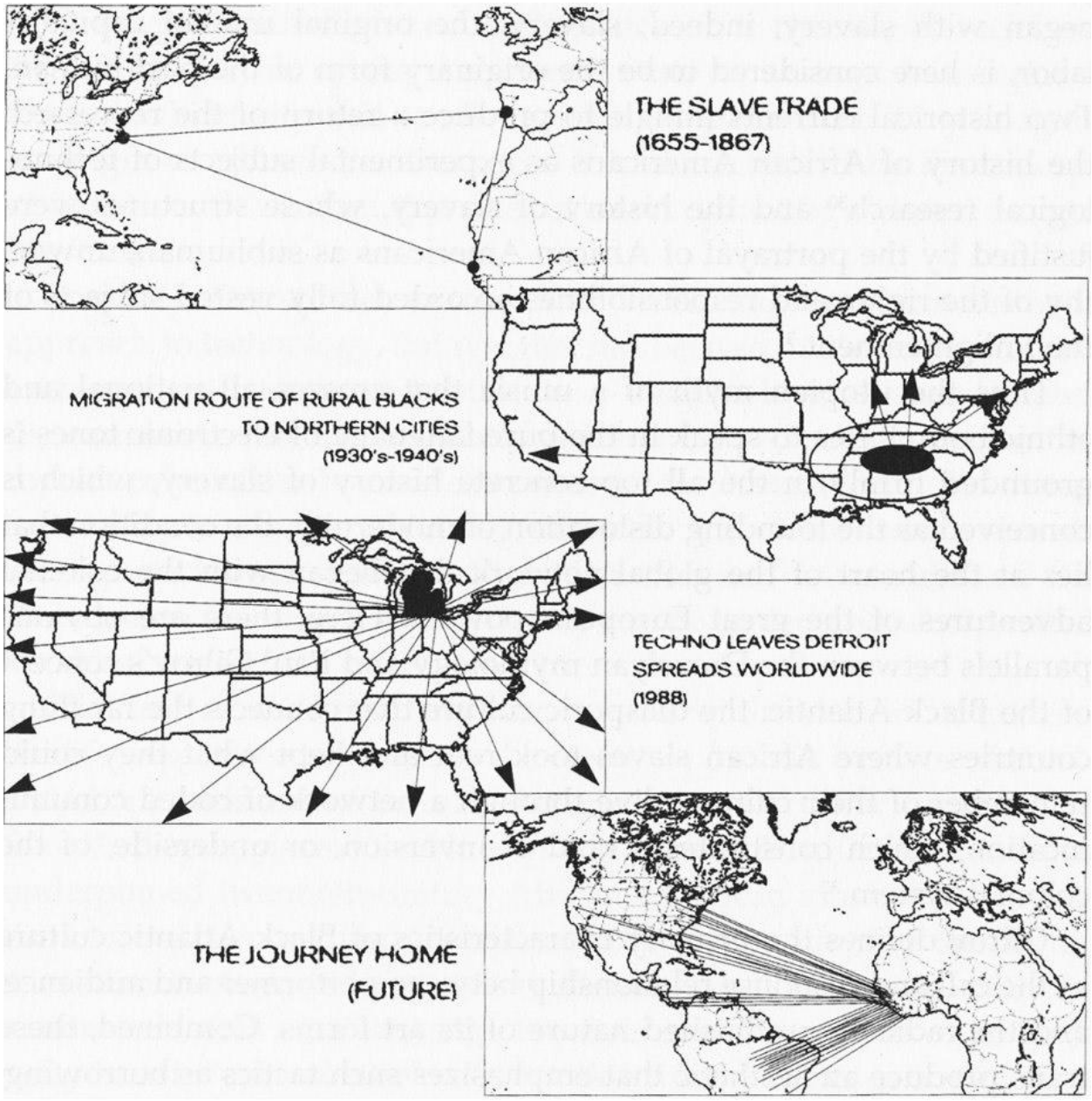
DeForrest Brown, Jr.

ASSEMBLING A BLACK COUNTER CULTURE

FIGURE ONE
Two Idealized Alternative Future Outcomes
to the Threat of Overshooting the Carrying Capacity of "Spaceship Earth"



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THE SLAVE TRADE
(1655-1867)
MIGRATION ROUTE OF RURAL BLACKS
TO NORTHERN CITIES
(1930's-1940's)
TECHNO LEAVES DETROIT
SPREADS WORLDWIDE
(1988)
THE JOURNEY HOME
(FUTURE)

White Silence: Introductory Notes on How the West Was Won

"You gotta look at it like, techno is technological. It's an attitude to making music that sounds futuristic: something that hasn't been done before."
—Juan Atkins, quoted in "Machine Soul: A History of Techno" [1]

"An imitation may be quite successful in its own way, but imitation can never be Success. Success is a first-hand creation."
—Henry Ford, *Ford News*[2]

Techno, as a historical artifact, derives its central premise from the act of African Americans dreaming of a future beyond the structural failings of a postindustrial collapse in the late twentieth century. The primary intention of this book is to remove the term, "techno," from the lexical electronic dance music industry standard of the hardcore continuum,[3] and resituate its original usage and meaning within the context of African American history and the community of the city of Detroit. Formulated out of a conceivably intuitive response to the urban degradation plaguing Detroit and other cities around the United States in the early 1980s, techno—rather than a generic component of a globalized music technology cartel and drug-induced nightlife

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[1] Juan Atkins, quoted in Jon Savage, "Machine Soul: A History of Techno," *The Village Voice* (Summer 1993), Rock & Roll Quarterly Insert

[2] Henry Ford, "2," *Ford News*, March 15, 1924, 2.

[3] Between 1992 and 1999, music journalist Simon Reynolds documented "a continuum of musical culture that emerged out of the British rave scene" in *The Wire* magazine:
"I call it a 'continuum' because that's what it is: a musical tradition/subcultural tribe that's managed to hold it together for nearly 20 years now, negotiating drastic stylistic shifts and significant changes in technology, drugs, and the social/racial composition of its own population. It's been a bumpy but exhilarating ride, but let no one doubt that it's the same rollercoaster at every stage of the journey (a ride which most likely has yet to reach its end). And I call it 'Hardcore' because the tradition started to take shape circa 1990 with what people called Hardcore Techno or Hardcore Rave, or sometimes simply Ardkore. These early sounds – bleep tunes from the North East, breakbeat house and ragga techno from London – were the first time that the UK came up with its own unique mutant versions of House and Techno (ironically by adding elements from dub reggae, dancehall, and hip hop that weren't British in origin, but equally would never have been let into the mix back in Chicago and Detroit). From Jungle and 2-step to today's Grime and Bassline, the basic parameters of the music have stayed the same as they were in the early Hardcore, although the relative balance of various sources (reggae, rap, R&B, Eurotechno, etc) has shifted, and the beats-per-minute rate has fluctuated wildly. Those core elements are: beat-science seeking the intersection between 'fucked up' and 'groovy'; dark bass pressure; MCs chatting fast over live-mixed DJ sets; samples and arrangement ideas inspired by pulp soundtracks and orchestrated pop. In a profound sense, underneath two decades of relentless sonic mutation, this is the same music, the same culture. What's also endured has been the scene's economic infrastructure: pirate radio stations, independent record shops (often in out-of-the-way urban areas), white labels and dubplates, specific rave promoters and clubs (again often in the less glitzy, non-central areas of cities)." Reynolds, "*The Wire* 300: Simon Reynolds on the Hardcore Continuum: Introduction," *The Wire,* February 2013,
https://www.thewire.co.uk/in-writing/essays/the-wire-300_simon-reynolds-on-the-hardcore-continuum_introduction.

economy[4]—is evidence of post–civil rights era Black youth adapting to their exposure to consumer technologies in the industrialized Northern states. At the same time, it attests to their opening up minds and hearts to a modernized method of expression that would transform the Black musical continuum into a technologically optimized form of soul music.

Juan Atkins first encountered the term “techno” in futurist and businessman Alvin Toffler’s 1980 book *The Third Wave*, which describes the transition of “developed” nations from industrial production to data-driven industries. Atkins was assigned the volume as a textbook in a class called “Future Studies” at Belleville High School, and Toffler’s concepts would present a promising theoretical backdrop for him as he began to experiment with his first electronic instruments at home. A sequel to *Future Shock*, which sought to define the cognitive states of societies living under the condition of “too much change in too short a period of time,"[5] *The Third Wave* detailed what Toffler suspected to be the long-term psychological and social effects of living in planned environments within a “one size fits all” model of technological production. Toffler warned of the industrial revolution's potential to destabilize class mobility and communities through a “technocratic divide” which favors the “informed” opinions of technical experts over a marginalized, and presumably unreliable, general public.[6] In short, Toffler concluded that within a technological society there exist two castes; when that society owned slaves to kickstart the process of developing such a system, the humanity of the undesignated caste became a dangerous loophole in the human condition.

Aktins’s use of the prefix “techno” was in direct reference to the word “technology,” which etymologically combines the idea of art or craft with emergent early seventeenth century logic stemming from the Greek word *tekhnologia*, meaning “systematic treatment.”[7] But it might also be considered a reference to Toffler’s use of the word “technocracy,” designating a society or governing system led by an elite class of technical experts who build platforms of production for a class of largely unskilled consumers. Toffler’s writing is a sober consideration of what American culture would eventually become: a civilization that treats the world and ways of living systematically, wherein society serves as a kind of medical treatment for humanity, pulling humans out of their “savage” engagements with nature. When factoring in the specificity of

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[4] Anthropologist and anarchist activist David Graeber describes an early example of economic barter systems amongst the Nambikwara population of Brazil as a kind of party, or rave, in which hundreds of people who were oftentimes “strangers, even enemies” negotiate the terms of a stock and exchange before “[...] everyone puts aside their weapons to sing and dance together—though the dance is one that mimics military confrontation.” David Graeber, *Debt: The First 5,000 Years* (Brooklyn, NY: Melville House, 2011), 29-30.

[5] “In 1965, in an article in *Horizon*, I coined the term ‘future shock’ to describe the shattering stress and disorientation that we induce in individuals by subjecting them to too much change in too short a time. Fascinated by this concept, I spent the next five years visiting scores of universities, research centers, laboratories, and government agencies, reading countless articles and scientific papers and interviewing literally hundreds of experts on different aspects of change, coping behavior, and the future. Nobel prizewinners, hippies, psychiatrists, physicians, businessmen, professional futurists, philosophers, and educators gave voice to their concern over change, their anxieties about adaptation, their fears about the future.” Alvin Toffler, *Future Shock* (New York: Random House, 1970), 4.

[6] Alvin Toffler, *The Third Wave* (New York: Bantam Books, 1980), 354.

[7] Henry George Liddell and Robert Scott, A Greek-English Lexicon (Abridged ed.) (Oxford, UK: Oxford University Press, 1980).

African Americans' four hundred-year-long history of oppression by means of an exclusively Anglo-Saxon colonial governing body, this understanding of technocracy appears a lot more sinister. Industry, as an operable structure in America, designates specific options within a set of limited, infallible conditions that extract hourly labor and statistical information from Americans to buffer natural materials towards projected immaterial gain in an imagined "future."

Twentieth-century understandings of society and culture irrevocably updated the value of nature and experience with the introduction of what Toffler calls a "collision of waves." These waves exist across the Western world's engagements with collections of individuals and their perceptually-owned environments, extending across techniques for cultivating a living condition in which nature nurtures the individual by means of distributed ownership. Space and place—as well as the people occupying both—become potentially limitless resources. Analyzing history as a "succession of rolling waves of change" with a potential leading edge, Toffler describes the development of the United States in three waves: 1. Agriculture, 2. Industry, and 3. Information. A 2011 interpretation of Toffler's alternative futures prediction–which can be seen in the previous pages of this book–focuses on the possibility that society may be due for a "mega-crisis" as the waves of change progress the manmade experiment of civilization forward into either an era of sustainability, or collapse.[8] When considering the development of capital and empire through twentieth century urban planning and technology, the annexing and reformatting of labor extraction must be brought into question as well. There is a direct correlation between the abolishment of the chattel slavery of African Americans and the rise of modern industrial complexes fueled by human bodies.[9] As a matter of function, the agricultural revolution sectioned off a plot of land as a formal zone of habitation: those living within it also occupy it as laborers. The industrial revolution optimized space with technologies that smoothed out the hardship of labor. Finally, the digital revolution transformed every resource, product, and laborer into a calculable imaginary whose existence is abstracted and consolidated into a singular, manageable use-value. Within a matter of decades Americans' relationship to labor, production, and ownership shifted from being independently cultivated as a private entrepreneurial practice by individuals living amongst and in semi-collaboration with other individuals, to a multiscale managerial model under which workers and their labor are consolidated into large, managerial organizational structures. Rather than produce for oneself, one's family, and one's community, the American worker began to offer their labor in the name of a greater good designated by corporate and government leaders. The dual decline of civilization and socialization is a process and result of gross extraction and accumulation. What America considers "normal" is an unfortunate white supremacist standard, preceded and set to scale by the communally-sanctioned and justified mass murder of native peoples of the Americas, and the kidnapping, torture, and enslavement of multiple factions of West African tribes who would be renamed "Negro."[10] Consequently, the United States operates as an experiment seeking to

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[8] Oliver Markley, "Manifesting Upside Recovery Instead of Downside Fear: Five Ways Megacrisis Anticipation Can Proactively Improve Futures Studies and Social Policy," *Journal of Futures Studies* 16, no. 2 (December 2011): 123-134.

[9] Cedric J. Robinson, *On Racial Capitalism, Black Internationalism, and Cultures of Resistance*, ed. H. L. T. Quan (London: Pluto Press, 2019), 9.

[10] Alexander Falconbridge, d. 1792, An Account of the Slave Trade On the Coast of Africa (London: J. Phillips, 1788).

replicate what a society and nation state could look like when starting from a cultural and ethnic blank slate. While civilizations have advanced through waves of agricultural, industrial, and most recently, digital revolutions since the Neolithic era,[11] within the context of American colonialism by British and European nations, and the importation of varying ethnically distinct West Africans to a place populated by indigenous communities, several waves of human development were collapsed into the five-hundred-year-long formative project of redesigning the Americas into the compositional structure of the United States. One must imagine Europe's understanding of the uncharted landscape of the Americas as a blank slate devoid of history and lived or inscribed experience.

From 1619—when the first West Africans were brought to American shores by the transatlantic slave trade—to today,[12] African Americans have lived in the United States as *de facto* hostages under the conditions of an unspoken second-class citizenship, bearing witness to the full brunt of the atrocities of the white colonial death drive in "the New World." The sound of techno exists as a peak intersection in Black history, reorganizing centuries of African American cultural expressions under capital and empire into a material and usable vibrational technology. While enslaved by British and European colonizers on the American continents, captured West Africans—who were kept from learning to read or write[13]—adapted a tradition of vocal outcries, which became songs, and redesigned a culture from remnants of rituals recuperated from their former homelands, communicating the grooves and passageways of a sub-alternate social reality through movement and dance.[14] The term "Black music" refers to a kind of music that is completely removed from the entire context of white European history, knowledge, and opinion[15] as a direct result of Black people strategically learning to speak, feel and be heard while in bondage.[16]

The initial voyages of Christopher Columbus across the Atlantic Ocean in 1492 initiated a process of expansion of the Western world into a broader formation. Columbus's landing in what is presently known as the Bahama Islands—named Guanahani by the indigenous population who occupied it—was an accidental discovery that began a process of cultural study,

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[11] C. Abegg, J. Desideri, O. Dutour, M. Besse, "More Than the Sum of Their Parts: Reconstituting the Paleopathological Profile of the Individual and Commingled Neolithic Populations of Western Switzerland," *Archaeological and Anthropological Sciences* 13, no. 44 (March 2021): https://doi.org/10.1007/s12520-021-01278-4.
[12] Beth Austin, "1619: Virginia's First Africans," Hampton History Museum, December 2018, https://hampton.gov/DocumentCenter/View/24075/1619-Virginias-First-Africans?bidId=.
[13] Smithsonian American Art Museum, "Literacy as Freedom," https://americanexperience.si.edu/wp-content/uploads/2014/09/Literacy-as-Freedom.pdf
[14] W. E. B. Du Bois, *The Souls of Black Folk* (New York, NY: Barnes & Noble Classics, 2003), 177. See also Kariamu Welsh-Asante, *African Dance* (Trenton, NJ: Africa World Press, 2002), xv.
[15] Du Bois, Ibid. See also, Amiri Baraka, *Blues People: Negro Music in White America* (Harper Perennial, 1963), 17.
[16] "Slave families were completely shattered and cultural continuity almost totally disrupted. The Blacks who were kidnapped and dragooned to these shores were not only stripped of most of their native African languages. They were forced to speak in the tongue of the masters and to adapt to the master's culture. In short, Blacks were the victims of a pervasive cultural imperialism which destroyed all but faint remnants (chiefly in music) of the old African forms." Robert L. Allen, *Black Awakening in Capitalist America: An Analytic History* (Trenton, NJ: Africa World Press, 1992), 13.

quasi-assimilation, and extraction. On a second voyage to the Americas, Columbus motioned against the suggestion of the Royal institution and captured upwards of 1,600 people from the Arawak tribe, with the intention of establishing a mechanical labor force to cultivate the surrounding environment as a resource that could generate outsourced income for the Spanish state. Of that 1,600, four hundred were able to journey back with Columbus, whose survey by the Royal family was released and sent back to America. Half became deathly sick due to contact with the Europeans and the Taino population were entirely wiped out.[17] Add to Christopher Columbus' "discovery" of "The New World," the capture and trade of slaves across the Atlantic Ocean: 10.7 million Africans are estimated to have survived the journey to North America, the Caribbean, and South America between 1525 and 1866, according to the Trans-Atlantic Slave Trade Database.[18] Historian Henry Louis Gates Jr. reports that, "In fact, an overwhelming percentage of the African slaves were shipped directly to the Caribbean and South America; Brazil received 4.86 million Africans alone!"[19] He documents that another sixty to seventy thousand Africans would eventually be transported to the United States from the Caribbean, remarking, "Incredibly, most of the 42 million members of the African-American community descend from this tiny group of less than half a million Africans. And I, for one, find this amazing."[20] Coupled together, these colonial enterprises in the New World ultimately pioneered the transformation of domestic, indentured servitude, which had existed on the European and African continents for thousands of years into a multinational economic enterprise.[21]

Capitalizing on a seventy-five-year-long investment in the fragmentation and colonization of Africa, the transatlantic slave trade began the project of mechanical reproduction of European culture and ideology onto foreign soil. Europe–much like a viral entity woven into the fabric of the Americas–overtime constructed an imaginary empire, participatory sport, and collective psychosis that expanded even further with the industrial revolution of the 1800s, which accelerated the landscaping and design of this newly captured space. The twentieth century, in comparison, could be considered interior decoration. American legal, constitutional, financial, and amendment documents are game pieces towards a fictional world of normalcy. Though the land of the Americas had been "tamed," modes of living had to be organized to effectively fuel the country's economy through industry, leading to a mass standardization of culture around labor and leisure as a subtle and effectively progressive form of continued colonialism. As a societal framework, the United States is decidedly malleable and erasable, and first and foremost, religiously ideological. By the 1960s the indigenous population had been reduced to

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[17] Robert M. Pool, "What Became of the Taino?," *Smithsonian Magazine*, October 2011, https://www.smithsonianmag.com/travel/what-became-of-the-taino-73824867/.
[18] https://www.slavevoyages.org/voyage/database, accessed July 30, 2021.
[19] Henry Louis Gates, Jr., "How Many Slaves Landed in the US?" *The Root*, January 6, 2014, https://www.theroot.com/how-many-slaves-landed-in-the-us-1790873989.
[20] Ibid.
[21] James C. Clark, "How Columbus Created Slave Trade That Changed the World's Economy," *The Orlando Sentinel*, May 17, 1992, https://www.orlandosentinel.com/news/os-xpm-1992-05-17-9205160196-story.html.

6.79 million[22] from a presumed 75 million[23] and the America that had come into formation was steeped in fractured European values, distorted Christian Science, and a systematic process for reproducing the appearance of a structurally-sound ethnostate, which would at no time acknowledge its torture of the African American population or the neardecimation of indigenous peoples. According to the 1950 US census, white Americans formed 90% of the population[24]; at this point in the long-term project of the colonization of America, individuals from Europe who now called themselves Americans had successfully seized control over the entirety of a continent. The color-based designation of race has long organized the inheritors of this wealth and free land into a hierarchical caste system.[25] Race, as opposed to ethnicity, operates as classification towards an economic ordinance, irrevocably branding African Americans as "Negroes."[26] In other words, American-born African descendants of the slave class are designated as being in an existential Black region, without wealth or value. Despite Black and white Americans inhabiting the same country for nearly half a millennium, the political and social dynamics structured by the transatlantic slave trade, continued through Jim Crow-era segregation and optimized into modern forms of perpetuated systemic racism have ensured that two timelines of the American narrative exist in tandem without much nonviolent crossover. Because of the status Black Americans and their labor contribution while enslaved, a more rigorous material examination must take place if there is to be any understanding of what it means to live a Black life as structurally subordinate to both workers and elites who wield and gamble a free-market democratic economy built upon the extraction and exploitation of Black bodies. As a reference text, this book intends to assemble an alternative viewpoint of the future from Black historical analyses and a contextual reexamination of articles, liner notes, interviews, and books published in the electronic dance music industry during the late twentieth century advent of technological and economic global consciousness.

In 1969, scholar Theodore Roszak published *The Making of a Counter Culture: Reflections on the Technocratic Society*—a book that circulated amongst hippies, beatniks, Vietnam veterans, radical student groups, and other categories of white American youth rebels who related to Roszak's opposition to the complex organizational structures of the technology-dominated society that had taken shape around them. White suburban inheritors of colonial wealth, guilt, and trauma—what Roszak called "technocracy's children"—were born into a technocratic regime run by industry experts. The youth of the 1960s were expected to fulfill specific roles in

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[22] "Native American Population 2021," World Population Review, accessed July 30, 2021, https://worldpopulationreview.com/state-rankings/native-american-population.
[23] Russell Thornton, "Population History of Native North Americans," in Michael R. Haines and Richard Hall Steckel, eds., *A Population History of North America* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2000), 36.
[24] Census
[25] "Caste and race are neither synonymous nor mutually exclusive. They can and do coexist in the same culture and serve to reinforce each other. Race, in the United States, is the visible agent of the unseen force of cast. Caste is the bones, race the skin. Race is what we can see, the physical traits that have been given arbitrary meaning and become shorthand for who a person is. Caste is the powerful infrastructure that holds each group in its place. Caste is fixed and rigid. Race is fluid and superficial, subject to periodic redefinition to meet the needs of the dominant caste in what is now the United States." Isabel Wilkerson, Caste: The Origins of Our Discontents (New York: Random House, 2020), pg. 18-19.
[26] W.E.B. Du Bois, "Of Our Spiritual Strivings," in *The Souls of Black Folk*, 7.

the industrial labor force, reinforce the nuclear family model, and invest in a prospective "future" of economic possibility from the basis of their generational inheritance. Roszak considered the counterculture to be a type of "matrix in which an alternative, but still excessively fragile future is taking shape."[27] Somewhat unconcerned with the holistic social stratification of people and cultures inhabiting and struggling against the United States and white hegemonic social structures, *The Making of a Counter Culture* privileged white youth culture as the torchbearer of the epic of America. Despite Roszak's understanding of technocracy, his scholarship delimited who can resist cultural optimization in a capitalist industrial complex. For him, the situation of Black oppression in America was case sensitive and not to be coupled with the movements of white collegiate youth:

> At this point, the counter culture I speak of embraces only a strict minority of the youth and a handful of their adult mentors. It excludes our more conservative young, for whom a bit less Social Security and a bit more of that old-time religion (plus more police on the beat) would be sufficient to make the Great Society a thing of beauty. It excludes our more liberal youth, for whom the alpha and omega of politics is no doubt still that Kennedy style. It excludes the scattering of old-line Marxist youth groups whose members, like their fathers before them, continue to tend the ashes of the proletarian revolution, watching for a spark to leap forth. More importantly, it excludes in large measure the militant black young, whose political project has become so narrowly defined in ethnic terms that, despite its urgency, it has become as culturally old-fashioned as the nationalist mythopoesis of the nineteenth century. In any event, the situation of black youth requires such special treatment as would run to book length in its own right.[28]

Assembling a Black Counter Culture seeks to acknowledge the obvious legitimacy and significance of Black liberation and fulfill the required "special treatment" that the situation of Black youth deserves. Techno music was invented by the Black youth of Detroit and inherited by the Black youth of today; it expresses an inherent romance and trauma that carries with it centuries worth of stories. Alvin Toffler wrote of techno-rebels who could gain access to the very technology intended to maintain and operate the living standards of white American society, and utilize it as "the basis for humanizing the technological thrust."[29] While Toffler's writing called for readers to not take for granted how novel and unpredictable a technological society is, the present book hopes to establish an understanding of the African American experience as distinct from, though intertwined, with the chaos of the twentieth century. *Assembling a Black Counter Culture* has several anchors, which collectively depict another plane of existence being communicated by the rhythms and vibrations of techno. Inspired by Diego Rivera's 1933 commissioned series of *Detroit Industry Murals* at the Detroit Institute of Arts, illustrator and futurist AbuQadim Haqq designed the cover of this book with an understanding that techno is an advanced vibrational technology that can be integrated into the mind, body, and soul; it creates

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[27] Theodore Roszak, *The Making of a Counter Culture*: *Reflections on the Technocratic Society and Its Youthful Opposition* (Garden City, NY: Anchor Books, 1969), xiii.
[28] Roszak, *The Making of a Counter Culture*, xii.
[29] Toffler, *The Third Wave*, 169.

"something of a higher dimensional soul technology that these artists access to reach the highest states of their soundcraft."[30] Haqq's connection with the sounds and circumstances of techno through decades of artistic contributions to classic Detroit record labels such as Metroplex, Transmat, and Underground Resistance informed the making of *The Technanomicron*, a thirty-page art book and CD compilation, in which he predicts "the rise of technolords" at the end of a thousand year, multigenerational evolution occurring at the end of the twentieth century, or toward the end of the future. He writes: "By enhancing their souls with vibrational technology, they were able to achieve new levels of awareness, creativity and discovery. Their vibrational creations were able to explore the darkest regions of space, travel multi-dimensionally and establish sonic empires."[31]

In Haqq's tightly woven epic tale, these figures—real and imagined—found existence across their own time and space continuum possible, even within the modern framework of a colonized American Empire and its attendant culture-industrial complexes. His mytho-science further evolved through his graphic novelization, *The Book of Drexciya*, which visualized the potential narratives and cultures underpinning James Stinson and Gerald Donald's exploration of the mythic Black Atlantic civilization of Drexciya in the early nineties. Haqq reconsider their insight and expansion of centuries-old African diasporic folktales that gave voice to the mass revolts and escapes from slave ships[32] which constitute, in part, the four-hundred-year context of African American migration—a context that frames Drexciya's 1997 compilation album, *The Quest*, as well as concepts from conversations with James Stinson during the making of *Neptune's Lair* in 1999. *The Book of Drexciya* envisioned the rise of Drexaha—the first King of the Drexciyan Empire—as an African diasporic bridge within a counterculture of modernity canonized in historian Paul Gilory's 1993 book *The Black Atlantic*.[33] British-Ghanian writer, theorist, and filmmaker Kodwo Eshun's 1998 study, *More Brilliant Than the Sun: Adventures in Sonic Fiction*, extended the speculative research, thought, and sonic experiments that index the adaptation of Africans across the diaspora to the then-industrial and now-cybernetic aspects of American-European colonization and modernity.[34] Engineering concepts and neologisms as a means of decoding and transcribing the essence of African usage of media and machines in the

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[30] AbuQadim Haqq, unpublished statement from https://arstechnica.com/gaming/2021/02/inside-the-stunning-black-mythos-of-drexciya-and-its-afrofuturist-90s-techno/.

[31] AbuQadim Haqq, *The Technanomicron* (Third Earth, 2008), 1

[32] "In May 1803 a group of enslaved Africans from present-day Nigeria, of Ebo or Igbo descent, leaped from a single-masted ship into Dunbar Creek off St. Simons Island in Georgia. A slave agent concluded that the Africans drowned and died in an apparent mass suicide. But oral traditions would go on to claim that the Eboes either flew or walked over water back to Africa." Thomas Hallock, "How a Mass Suicide by Slaves Caused the Legend of the Flying African to Take Off," *The Conversation*, February 18, 2021, https://theconversation.com/how-a-mass-suicide-by-slaves-caused-the-legend-of-the-flying-african-to-take-off-153422.

[33] "This book addresses one small area in the grand sequence of this historical conjunction–the stereophonic, bilingual, or bifocal cultural forms originated by, but no longer the exclusive property of, Blacks dispersed within the structures of feeling, producing, communicating, and remembering that I have heuristically called the Black Atlantic world." Paul Gilroy, *The Black Atlantic: Modernity and Double Consciousness* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1993), 3.

[34] Kodwo Eshun, *More Brilliant Than The Sun: Adventures in Sonic Fiction* (London: Quartet Books, 1998).

context of electronic dance music, Eshun outlined what Underground Resistance described as the "operating system for the redesign of sonic reality."[35] His later article, "Further Considerations on Afrofuturism," further conceptualized the Black Atlantic counterculture as a fragmented diasporic consciousness capable of reorienting the architectural trajectory of modern history.[36]

We could also turn to *The Last Angel of History*,[37] a 45-minute fictional documentary by John Akomfrah and Edward George of the Black Audio Film Collective that introduces the "Data Thief," a poet and scavenger of history played by George, who travels through time, studying the connection between the displacement of Africans across the diaspora and the innovative music that emerged from those Africans with the advent of consumer technologies. Throughout the film, the Data Thief explores George Clinton's concept of "The Mothership Connection" as it relates to Afrofuturist visions of otherBlack musicians like Sun Ra, alongside talking head commentary by Detroit techno musicians Juan Atkins, Derrick May, and Carl Craig; writers Samuel R. Delany, Octavia E. Butler, Ishmael Reed, Greg Tate, and Kodwo Eshun; and electronic music producers DJ Spooky, Goldie, and A Guy Called Gerald. As the documentary opens, the Data Thief describes the origin of the Black vocal music tradition explored in playwright and critic Amiri Baraka's 1963 book *Blues People: Negro Music in White America*—a tradition that would be standardized and exported through the recording music industry,[38] while slavery continued after the Civil War and into the 1960s, alongside Jim Crow-era segregation, white supremacist terrorism, and the institution of a prison industrial complex.[39] He remarks:

> We came across a story of a bluesman from the 1930s, a guy called Robert Johnson. Now the story goes, that Robert Johnson sold his soul to the devil at a crossroads in the Deep South. He sold his soul, and in return, he was given the secret of a Black technology, a Black secret technology, that we now know to be the blues. The blues begat jazz, the blues begat soul, the blues begat hip-hop, the blues begat R&B.[40]

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[35] Eshun, Ibid., 7.
[36] Kodwo Eshun, "Further Considerations on Afrofuturism," *CR: The New Centennial Review* 3, no. 2, globalicities: possibilities of the globe (Summer 2003): 287-302.
[37] John Akomfrah (dir.), *The Last Angel of History*, 1996, color, 45 mins (Icarus Films)
[38] "For one class of Negroes, as the developing strata of the city emphasized, the blues could extend in a kind of continuum from rhythm & blues all the way back to country blues. In the cities all these forms sat side by side in whatever new confusions urban life offered, and the radio made them all equally of the moment. Although at this point rhythm & blues was the most constantly played blues music heard throughout the country, it also created a revived demand for the older form—to be played on those same radio circuits." Amiri Barka, *The Blues People* (Harper Perennial, 1963), 171
[39] See Antoinette Harrell as told to Justin Fornal, "Black People in the US Were Enslaved Well Into the 1960s," *Vice*, February 28, 2016, https://www.vice.com/en/article/437573/blacks-were-enslaved-well-into-the-1960s?utm_campaign=sharebutton; ACLU, "School-to-Prison Pipeline," ACLU, accessed July 31, 2021, https://www.aclu.org/issues/juvenile-justice/school-prison-pipeline; "The Untold History of Post-Civil War 'Neoslavery'," NPR, Talk of the Nation, March 25, 2008, https://www.npr.org/templates/story/story.php?storyId=89051115
[40] The Data Thief, in *The Last Angel of History*, Ibid.

Two hundred years into a speculative future and investigating the interconnected web of Black culture, the Data Thief was told of a crossroads similar to the one Robert Johnson had encountered: “If you can find the crossroads, a crossroads, this crossroads, if you can make an archeological dig into this, you’ll find fragments, techno-fossils. And if you can put those elements, those fragments together, you’ll find the code. Crack that code, and you’ll have the keys to your future. You’ve got one clue and it’s a phrase: Mothership Connection.” In his studies, the Data Thief discovers the word “Africa,” the concept of “the New World,” and two rooms marked “Lee Perry Black Ark” and “Sun Ra Arkestra,” while searching for the secret of the Mothership Connection. Lee Perry and Sun Ra tell him that “Our music is a mirror of the universe. We explore the future through music.” Kodwo Eshun appears in the film to discuss the writings of Greg Tate and further his considerations of Afrofuturism and the transportation of Africans from “the Old World” to “the New World”: “All the stories about alien abductions, all the stories about alien spaceships taking subjects from one place and taking them to another, genetically transforming them,” Eshun reflects, “[h]ow much more alien do you think it gets than slavery? Than entire mass populations moved and genetically altered, entire status moved, forcibly dematerialized? It doesn’t really get much more alien than that.” Turning to electronic music, Eshun continues, suggesting that, consumer technologies of the Western postwar period empowered young Black people, who were able to gain access to discarded synthesizers, drum machines, and sequencers to create techno and a new digital audio ecology:

> The connection between the architects of Afrofuturism, between Sun Ra, and Lee Perry, and George Clinton, and between techno and jungle later on in the ’80s and the ’90s, is simply that they pulled nothing in common with the common idea of Black music, which is that it belongs to the street or to the stage. They need a live music nor they—kind of muses that exists out in the urban. They’re studio music, they’re impossible, imaginary music. And yet, because they’re imaginary, they’re even more powerful because they suggest the future. They don’t reflect the past. They imagine the future.[41]

Detroit techno—a concept of sonic world-building and coded information exchange born out of a centuries-long lineage of African American struggle and insurrection—would eventually be exported, repackaged, and financialized within foreign markets as a colloquial term and categorical standard of 120-140 beats per minute to be assimilated into the multicultural “hardcore continuum” of the British and European post-colonial drug and rave revolution—replicating the profit-oriented process of extraction. Yet Detroit techno builds upon previous iterations of African American uprisings, from the first slave insurrection in 1505, to the Bacon’s Rebellion of 1676, the Nat Turner Rebellion of 1831, the Red Summer of 1919, and the long, hot summer of 1967, when riots spread across the US in the aftermath of the state-initiated assassinations of Martin Luther King, Jr. and Malcolm X.[42] Situated within this lineage, *Assembling a Black Counter Culture* charts a survey of the works of key Detroit techno producers, working in the context of a transitional moment in Black history and in the

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[41] Kodwo Eshun in *The Last Angel of History*, Ibid.
[42] Roland Sheppard, “The Assassinations of Malcolm X and Martin Luther King Jr.,” *Marxists.org*, last updated May 25, 2021, https://www.marxists.org/history/etol/writers/rsheppard/malcolmandking.htm / http://tech.mit.edu/V120/N16/col16guest.16c.html/.

overwhelming framework of a capitalist, post-industrial America.[43] To do this, the book acknowledges Cybotron's simulations of modern metroplexes through experiments in sonic technology and stereophonic intelligence; the Belleville Three's articulation and popularization of the term "techno" as a descriptor of sense-altering electronic funk and hi-tech soul in the midst of inner city decay; Underground Resistance's mobilization of tactical electronic warfare accompanied by chords of healing by the hi-tech jazz ensemble Galaxy 2 Galaxy; and Drexciya's coded cartographic audio visualizations of a "Journey Home." A journey beyond the savage and failing free market capitalist industrial system imagined within the frames of white American technological utopianism.

[43] "Since the masses of Black people are not going to be integrated into the economy in the foreseeable future, as the reformers would have one believe, and since there are few signs of an imminent revolution in this country, contrary to the hopes of some radicals, it is necessary for the Black liberation movement to devise a transitional program, which will operate until such time as conditions develop that will make possible full liberation through social revolution." Robert L. Allen, *Black Awakening in Capitalist America:* 274.

1. **Techno City, The Final Frontier**

“Greetings to the privileged generation of Earth. One hundred years ago, millions of people across the expanse of your planet looked into the heavenly skies… and they asked the question, ‘What would life be like in the year 1981?’”
—The Electrifying Mojo[44]

“Millions are already attuning their lives to the rhythms of tomorrow. Others, terrified of the future, are engaged in a desperate, futile flight into the past and are trying to restore the dying world that gave them birth. The dawn of this new civilization is the single most explosive fact of our lifetimes.”
—Alvin Toffler, *The Third Wave*[45]

In today’s social memory, techno is considered an international phenomenon and globalized product of the leisure class, promoting the liberation of mind, body, and soul through continuous electronic music, ecstatic dance, and transcendent experience. Yet, the initial ingredients of “techno”[46] were assembled conversationally between Juan Atkins and Rik Davis in the early 1980s, then imaginative bedroom studio producers who had formed the group Cybotron. These sounds would be shared with and expanded upon by Derrick May, Eddie Fowlkes, James Pennington, Anthony “Shake” Shakir, Blake Baxter, and Kevin Saunderson over the course of the decade. At this time in the mid-1980s, the reel-to-reel and turntable-based underground “house”[47] music coming out of Chicago from Farley "Jackmaster" Funk, Ron Hardy, Frankie Knuckles, and Jesse Saunders, or New York, from Larry Levan crossed over with Detroit techno’s technological sonic fictions when the pre-owned, often discontinued electronic equipment being used to concoct and transmit a shared alternate reality became more accessible to consumers. British journalist and talent scout Neil Rushton caught wind of the influx of house music exports to the United Kingdom and reached out to Derrick May to invest in what looked to be a burgeoning economy. *Techno! The New Dance Sound of Detroit* hit shelves on May 4,1988, compiling a decade of Detroit electronic music into a single package represented by Juan Atkins, Derrick May, and Kevin Saunderson as the marketable young pioneers, the “Belleville Three.” While the album introduced the term “techno” to European music listeners, recognition of the sound's origins in middle class Black America did not spread

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[44] The Electrifying Mojo, quoted in Ashley Zlatopolsky, “Theater of the Mind: The Legacy of the Electrifying Mojo,” Red Bull Music Academy Daily, May 12, 2015.
https://daily.redbullmusicacademy.com/2015/05/electrifying-mojo-feature/
[45] Toffler, *The Third Wave*, 25.
[46] “Techno is music that sounds like technology, and not technology that sounds like music, meaning that most of the music you listen to is made with technology, whether you know it or not. But with techno music, you know it.” Juan Atkins Interview, *Dance Music Report,* 1992.
[47] “The word ‘house’ comes from a record that you only hear in a certain club. The DJs would search out an import that was as obscure as possible, and that would be a house record. You'd hear a certain record only at the Powerplant, and that was Frankie Knuckles’ house record. But you couldn’t really be guaranteed an exclusive on an import, 'cos even if there were only 10 or 15 copies in the country, another DJ would track one down. So the DJs came up with the concept of making their own house records. It was like ‘hey, I know I've got an exclusive because I made the record.” Juan Atkins, interview with Simon Trask, “Future Shock,” *Music Technology Magazine* (December 1988): 42.

as far or wide. A process of assimilating techno into the British and European rave culture industry was initiated by the compilation itself, as early as the sleeve notes penned by Scottish journalist, Stuart Cosgrove: “Think of Detroit,” he wrote, “and you automatically think of Motown, but be careful not to think too loud because the new grandmasters of Detroit techno hate history.”[48]

Detroit—nicknamed “The Motor City”—emerged as the United States’ fourth largest city in the 1920s, greatly contributing to the rising standards of living across the nation with its investments in the “Big Three” (Ford, Chrysler, and General Motors) automotive empire. Black Detroit’s early twentieth century musical history—from the blues and jazz of Old Hastings Street in the 1920s to Motown in the 1960s—thrived because of the auto industry, and loomed over the youth counterculture that was beginning to experiment with turntables, drum machines, synthesizers, and other studio recording devices as a way of absorbing and distilling the rhythm and soul of the past into a form of progressive music that eventually became techno. “Berry Gordy built the Motown sound on the same principles as the conveyor belt system at the Ford Plant. Today the automotive plants use robots and computers to make the cars, and I'm more interested in Ford's robots than Gordy's music,” Juan Atkins remarked.[49] Learning from his time as an assembly line worker at Henry Ford’s Lincoln-Mercury Plant, Berry Gordy founded Tamla Records—later renamed Motown Records in the late 1950s—with the intent of applying Ford’s managerial strategy to mass-produce Black music as an efficient, pristine, and readily consumable commodity. “At the plant, the cars started out as just a frame, pulled along on conveyor belts until they emerged at the end of the line…,” Gordy explained. “I wanted the same concept for my company, only with artists and songs and records. I wanted a place where a kid off the street could walk in one door an unknown and come out another a recording artist—a star.”[50] Throughout the 1960s and the Civil Rights Movement, the Motown “hit factory”—a portmanteau of “motor” and “town”—would parallel the success of Detroit’s automotive industry, earning 110 top ten hits on the Billboard charts throughout the ’60s and fulfilling a version of Gordy’s dream to “educate customers about the beauty of jazz.”[51] Gordy sold optimized soul music from African American ensembles of vocalists, session musicians, and studio engineers, who were recruited and assembled under contract to produce copyrighted populist earworms that could be experienced, consumed, and by all demographics under the slogan: “The Sound of Young America.”

In 1960, the Ford Foundation hired urbanist, lawyer and housing expert Charles Abrams to study what he described as “urban problems in our urban age,” with the goal of initiating urban renewal projects by improving the housing conditions of the American people. Abrams eventually published the study in 1967 as the book *The City Is the Frontier*,[52] which put heavy

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[48] Stuart Cosgrove, sleeve notes, *Techno! The New Dance Sound of Detroit*, Virgin 10 Records, 1988, 2xLP.
[49] Juan Atkins, cited in Cosgrove, sleeve notes, *Techno! The New Dance Sound of Detroit*, Ibid.
[50] Chris Perkins, “How Detroit Assembly Lines Changed Music Forever,” *Road and Track*, October 29, 2020, https://www.roadandtrack.com/car-culture/a34518490/motown-assembly-line-berry-gordy/.
[51] Berry Gordy, To be loved: The Music, the Magic, the Memories of Motown: An Autobiography (New York, NY: Warner Books, 1994), 61
[52] Charles Abrams, *The City Is the Frontier* (New York: Harpers & Row, 1967).

emphasis on the regulation of housing and the economic status of African Americans facing daily racial discrimination, while providing blueprints and examples of ways to design cities as comfortable environments that could improve American citizens' everyday lives. Abrams called for a standardized, modern way of living across all metropolitan cities in the United States in the wake of the country's three hundred year history of displacement, development, and rationalization. He closed his study with the presentation of a "new philosophy for cities" that would dismantle the divide between the city and the suburbs, as well as redefine the city's role in state and federal funding to support general welfare for its citizens and their right to live. That same year, in the midst of the hippie revolution and the "Summer of Love," racial tensions between Black and white Americans boiled over in Detroit—and over one hundred other cities in the United States—resulting in a riot that left forty-five people dead and over two thousand buildings destroyed, eventually leading to mass "white flight" from the city of Detroit to the suburbs. Stuart Cosgrove more recently in 2016 published *Detroit 67: The Year That Changed Soul*, detailing the 1967 race riots within the context of the chaotic Vietnam war and Motown's exodus from Detroit to Los Angeles. "It was a summer of street-level rebellion when the complex threads that held Detroit together finally unravelled," he recalled in a 2015 interview with the Daily Record. "I was making toast in my mum's kitchen in a council house in Perth as a live report led the BBC Scotland news and I can still remember the sense of wonder, disbelief and history in the American reporter's voice as he said the prophetic words: 'What has happened to America? The Motor City is burning?'"[53] Cultural critic and Dean Emeritus at the College of Creative Studies in Detroit Vince Carducci offers a brief history of Motown's industrialization of music, alongside the financial collapse of the Motor City:

> The late 1960s and early 1970s saw the first outsourcing of the American automobile industry with investments in the maquiladoras of Mexico, a transformation in manufacturing often referred to as post-Fordist to distinguish it from the previous production regime. So, too, did Motown begin its exit from the city that gave it its name, a mission accomplished in 1972 when its headquarters officially moved from Detroit to Los Angeles. As with the auto industry, Motown left many workers behind, including the Funk Brothers. Most of the Motown records of this period, including Stevie Wonder's classics Music of My Mind, Talking Book, and Innervisions, featured freelance studio musicians recording at outsourced facilities in New York or LA (in addition to Wonder's multi-instrumental talents). The exception was Marvin Gaye's What's Going On, the first Motown record for which the Funk Brothers received liner-note credit and generally considered the greatest soul album ever made.[54]

In the years after Motown's departure from Detroit, a youthful Black music scene gained access to secondhand electronic instruments, underused recording studios, and mastering plants to develop a "progressive music" in the aftermath of the large-scale failure to desegregate Black

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[53] Stuart Cosgrove, "Motown burning: How Detroit exploded in the summer of 1967 as stars made the world dance while their city was ablaze," The Daily Mail, 2015 https://www.dailyrecord.co.uk/news/uk-world-news/motown-burning-how-detroit-exploded-5164489

[54] Vince Carducci, "Manufacturing Motown," Popmatters, 2009 https://www.popmatters.com/69384-manufacturing-motown-2496071565.html

and white communities throughout the United States. From 1977 to the mid-80s, Charles Johnson took on the mantle of The Electrifying Mojo as a vehicle for sharing crafted sonic journeys on WGPR (Where God's Presence Radiates)—the first Black owned and operated radio station in the United States.[55] Amplifying his cosmology of the "Theater of the Mind," Johnson's novel sensibility for musical eclecticism and transmutability of space, place, and one's emotional attachment to both through sonic programming was a skill honed by buying and DJing imported music while stationed in the Philippines as an active duty officer in the US Air Force. Mojo's show was presented to a primarily urban Black audience every night at 10pm. His show eventually became a beacon of cultural cohesion, wherein songs were played as a cinematic soundtrack while he spoke his mind and truth—to Ontario, Ohio, Michigan and the world—for an hour, occasionally driving through and conversing with the local communities of Black Detroit. Mojo relocated from WGPR in 1982 to WJLB, another legacy radio station, broadcasting urban contemporary and quiet storm to a growing African American middle class from the top of the eighth tallest building in the world, Detroit's Penobscot Building. The elevated vantage point inspired the new, on-air studio concept of the "Mothership," in connection to George Clinton's assemblage of the Motown-inspired Parliament–Funkadelic ensembles. Building on P-Funk's liberation of Black music through psychedelic, Afrofuturist explorations of mental and emotional states in the post-Civil Rights era,[56] The Electrifying Mojo instrumentalized the airwaves to design a sonic fiction as an overlay to the everyday lives and urban blues of the beginning of the information age. He remarked in a 1995 interview with *Black Journal* that he "just wanted to be a voice on the radio, a face in the crowd, a figment of the imagination."[57] And he felt that, "When you elevate [a persona] too high on a pedestal, you remove yourself from the earshot of what regular people have to say and how they feel, and sometimes that makes it impossible to relate on a relative level."[58]

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[55] WGPR was established in 1964 by lawyer and minister William Venoid Banks of the International Free and Accepted Modern Masons. See Kelley O'Neill, "The Nation's First Black-Owned TV Station, Founded in Detroit, Is Now a Historic Landmark," *Detroit Metro Times*, February 17, 2021, https://www.metrotimes.com/detroit/the-nations-first-black-owned-tv-station-founded-in-detroit-is-now-a-historic-landmark/Content?oid=26461644.

[56] "It was a metaphor for the boundlessness of art, and also for the ways that art found its way to people; the Mothership Connection had something to do with an extraterrestrial DJ beaming booty-shaking, soulquaking, mind-liberating music down to the Earth's benighted inhabitants." Ben Greenman, "Mothership Connection"—Parliament (1975)," Library of Congress, 2011, https://www.loc.gov/static/programs/national-recording-preservation-board/documents/MothershipConnection.pdf.

[57] *Black Journal* was the first nationally broadcasted African American television program. Reporting on politics and urban life during the Civil Rights and Black Liberation Movements from an African American perspective. "*Black Journal*'s claim to advocacy and community was openly stated from the first episode, in June 1968: in his introduction, the host, Lou House, said, 'It is our aim in the next hour and in the coming months to report and review the events, the dreams, the dilemmas of Black America and Black Americans.' The program editor Lou Potter told a journalist later that year, 'Our challenge was to do something truly new and meaningful: Not just Black faces bearing a white message, but black ideals, Black achievements-a Black world.' *Black Journal* was designed to foster a shared vision of a national Black community by transcending regional, generational, and class differences in its coverage. Black Journal had the potential to present its audience with a vision of common ground." Devorah Heitner, "No Thanks for Tokenism: Telling Stories from a Black Nation, *Black Journal*, 1968-1970," in *Black Power TV* (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 2013), 85.

[58] Detroit Black Journal Interview: The Electrifying Mojo

The Electrifying Mojo's mission to "save Detroit and the world from the musical blahs" undoubtedly had an effect on the young producers who later ignited the electronic dance music revolution that is "techno": it provided them with a window into other worlds and a blueprint for developing a lasting, personal, and cerebral relationship to music of all genres that would usher Mojo's community of listeners through a voyage of several varying segments each night. Beginning with an opening sequence of the "Landing of the Mothership" at 10pm, Mojo would speak over blended spaceship sound effects, segwaying into the "Awesome '84, '85" segment in which he played new music, or entire albums, before drifting down "Lover's Lane" with a half hour of R&B and "slow jams." The final movement of The Electrifying Mojo's broadcast invited listeners to join the "Midnight Funk Association." Before being inducted with the brain-rewiring carnal syncopations of electro[59] and funk acts like Parliament-Funkadelic, the Gap Band, and Zapp, Mojo beckoned listeners:

> Will the members of the Midnight Funk Association please rise? Please go to your porch light and turn it on for the next hour to show us your solidarity. If you're in your car please honk your horn and flash your lights, wherever you are. If you're in bed, get ready to dance on your back, in Technicolor. And get ready for the MFA. The word is… Hold on tight, don't let go. Whenever you feel like you're nearing the end of your rope, don't slide off. Tie a knot. Keep hanging, keep remembering, that it ain't nobody bad like you. This session of the international Midnight Funk Association is being called to order. Electrifying Mojo presiding. May the Funk be with you. Always…

The Midnight Funk Association sometimes ran overtime, extending into the early morning with open-ended segments[60] where listeners could call in requesting a "shout-out," and submit to the competitive mix series, "Star Wars," or "the Mixadome," a citywide mix-off. The Electrifying Mojo was an innovator in the Black community and radio broadcasting, beaming in sounds from distant lands that expanded the imaginations of anyone his signals reached. Mojo even aired a rare interview with Prince in 1985 following a birthday concert at Cobo Arena. "He was an underground cult hero. We would listen to him religiously every night," Juan Atkins once reminisced. "You'd sit there in a trance waiting for each record."[61]

Stuart Cosgrove's liner notes for that inaugural compilation, *Techno!* failed to identify the exact influence Mojo had had on the collective imaginations and emotions of the "Belleville Three,"

Clip: Season 45 Episode 35 | 1m 51s, https://video.kpbs.org/video/detroit-black-journal-interview-electrifying-mojo-emdg5d/ https://video.kpbs.org/video/detroit-black-journal-interview-electrifying-mojo-emdg5d/

[59] "[...]Cybotron coincided with the birth of a sound known as "electro," presumably a shortening of "electronic funk." Electro was one of the great dance music developments of the early 1980s that was neither a derivation nor an extension of disco. Instead, it was a "switched-on" funk variant, exaggerating the electronic sounds that Midwestern groups like Parliament-Funkadelic had perfected in the studio and brought onstage. Most critics point to New York, however, for the genre's watershed moment." Dan Sicko, *Techno Rebels: The Renegades of Electronic Funk* (Detroit: Wayne State University Press, 2010), 45.

[60] http://www.artandpopularculture.com/The_Electrifying_Mojo

[61] Atkins, in Zlatopolsky, "Theater of the Mind: The Legacy of the Electrifying Mojo."

claiming that techno was a “post-soul” music defining “a deliberate break with previous traditions of Black America music.” When asked about the phrase in a 2000 interview, Neil Rushton noted that “techno” was being used as an adjective as opposed to a hard label, denoting a quality of sound rather than a name: “[W]hen I went over to license the album, which was the first time I’d met either Kevin or Juan [Atkins], whereas before Derrick had said ‘techno’ in passing, they were all saying it. But they weren’t using it as a description for the records they were making. It was just a phrase that they used.”[62] Derrick May was labeled the “philosopher” of Detroit techno because of his keen understanding of how to describe the music, which he called a "complete mistake” and “like George Clinton and Kraftwerk caught in an elevator, with only a sequencer to keep them company.”[63] A knowing lyrical wit can be detected in May’s illustration, which quite clearly challenges the types of assumptions that could be made about the neutral image of a Black man and European men engaging in cultural exchange. The ironic truth of the matter is that George Clinton’s innate ability to create sense-altering pulses through electronic synthesizers would more or less overtake and hotwire Kraftwerk’s structural test sequences, much like what is heard in Juan Atkins’s 1987 Model 500 song “Sound of Stereo”[64] or Derrick May’s explanation of his own music as a kind of hi-tech soul that exists “beyond the beat.”[65]

May also articulated the difference between Chicago house and Detroit techno: “It's a question of respect, house still has its heart in 70's disco, we don't have any of that respect for the past, it's strictly future music. We have a much greater aptitude for experimentation”—and what became of the city after the explosive decades of racial tension and techno’s exportation to the UK. “The old industrial Detroit is falling apart,” he noted, “the structures have collapsed. It's the murder capital of America. Six-year-olds carry guns and thousands of Black people have stopped caring if they ever work again. If you make music in that environment it can't be straight music. In Britain you have New Order, well our music is the New Disorder.”[66] Bill Brewster and Frank Broughton–two former editors at the British clubbing magazine Mixmag who wrote a history of DJing titled *Last Night a DJ Saved My Life* in 1999–described the concepts and terminology that Juan Atkins had developed while collaborating with Rik Davis as “sci-fi mumbo-jumbo,” writing, “Because Detroit’s decay is striking and there’s no club scene to write about, the music was relentlessly characterised as a soundtrack to post-urban desolation, rather than music to make people sweat on a dance floor.”[67] Brewster and Broughten imagined that “the fact that techno is made with computers somehow became a mysterious truth about

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[62] Neil Rushton, Interview by Bill Brewster, originally published in DJ History, February 2000. Republished in Red Bull Music Academy, July 6, 2017, https://daily.redbullmusicacademy.com/2017/07/neil-rushton-interview.

[63] Derrick May

[64] “Yes, Kraftwerk was definitely an influence on my professional recording career. But this was two years after I had already been dealing with synthesizers. The beauty of first hearing Kraftwerk was that the sounds were so similar to what I was doing, and these guys were halfway across the planet. I knew it was electronic as soon as I heard it. But the thing is that their stuff was clean and precise. . .[while] I had all kinds of weird UFO sounds. . .it [Atkins’s music] was [more] psychedelic.”
Juan Atkins, Techno Rebels

[65] May

[66] Derrick May, *Techno! The New Dance Sound of Detroit, 1988*

[67] Bill Brewster and Frank Broughton, Last Night a DJ Saved My Life (New York, NY: Grove Press), 356

mankind's cybernetic future."[68] They asked Rushton if the "technological stuff was thought up after the fact, or was…part and parcel of what they were doing?" Rushton responded:

> I don't know. I'm always a bit skeptical about all of that. One of the things I always thought was the techno stuff had a jazz feel to it—as Carl Craig proved later—and when we were over there we kept saying that. We kept making comparisons to the past. And the other thing people got completely wrong is this image of techno being a new wave of dance music made in super studios. In fact, it was all made on old equipment. There were a lot of paradoxes going on there. I think that Derrick was very articulate and was quick to see what people wanted.[69]

The Belleville Three featured in the May issue of *The Face* magazine in an article written by Cosgrove titled "Seventh City Techno." Further adapting the origin story of "Detroit's new robosound," he defined techno as "the sound of young Detroit: built with machines, and driven by despair…." Alongside additional profiles of Blake Baxter and the Detroit house music group, Members of House, Cosgrove retells the story of *Gambit and Associates*, an underground comic written and drawn by Detroit DJ and artist Alan Oldham—a childhood friend of May's—which shipped with copies of Derrick May's "Nude Photo" 12-inch as Rhythim is Rhythim.[70] *Gambit and Associates* takes place in a world under the control of a "weird technocracy," visualizing a futuristic metropolis in the place of present-day postindustrial reality….[71] To set the scene, Cosgrove notes that Detroit is the murder capital of the United States, before introducing the comic's lead character Johnny Gambit, who stands as an archetype of Alvin Toffler's techno-rebel: "a big fan of Belgian group Front 242, and a dude who can draw a gun at 122 beats-per-minute." Cosgrove's article shifts into a series of profiles of the Belleville Three, listing each of the key players and their varying monikers while surveying the climate of the Detroit scene and its technological sound, comparing it to modern soul singers like Whitney Houston, Anita Baker, and Alexander O'Neill who were defining Black popular music towards the end of the '80s. "I don't really sing," Blake Baxter told Cosgrove. "I speak in a soft voice almost like hiding beneath the beat. I love records with whispering vocals—it's nothing like the gospel sound."[72] Kevin Saunderson pointedly addressed Detroit's initially mild reception to techno at a time when there was a noticeable increase in the production and sales of popular music, saying that he was fired from a radio station for being "too ahead of his time." "I took them a clipping from *Billboard* and they told me to come back when we were on the front cover," He remembered. "That's Detroit. I've turned my back on this city. I don't care if they don't buy one of my records—other people will."[73] Derrick May also had a story of being let go from a nightclub

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[68] Ibid.
[69] Rushton, interview with Brewster, DJ History, Ibid.
[70] "In the 80s, comics were changing with 'Love and Rockets', 'Mister X', and the first modern Japanese Manga and Anime were coming to America at that time. I was into New Wave at the time, too (not so much punk, I liked the stylish stuff and still do). So I combined all those influences into one character, "Johnny Gambit". Once I kind of made my own style, I got noticed and published." Alan Oldham, interview, "Drawing a Picture: Alan Oldham," Innate, June 10, 2014, https://inn8.net/interview-with-alan-oldham/.
[71] Stuart Cosgrove, " Seventh City Techno," *The Face* (May 1988): PAGES.
[72] Blake Baxter, quoted in Cosgrove, Ibid., PAGE.
[73] Kevin Saunderson, quoted in Cosgrove, Ibid. PAGE.

with a ballroom dance floor named the Lidernacht, or Night Song in German, which catered to industrial music. “They only wanted to hear The Smiths or Severed Heads. I was playing Black underground sounds and they couldn’t take it,” Having worked to build a racially-mixed crowd at the club, May described the manager eventually dismissing his efforts because he didn’t want to operate a Black club before firing and banning May for life. “They used to say ‘Get this nigger shit off!’ They even went as far as having a sit-down strike on the dancefloor. All these dickheads in black shirts trying to be so English and so progressive and refusing to listen to underground music that was happening under their noses.”[74]

Exasperated, May continued, “This city is in total devastation. Factories are closing, people are drifting away, and kids are killing each other for fun. The whole order has broken down. If our music is a soundtrack to all of that, I hope it makes people understand.” Cosgrove takes stock of the local scene, rejecting techno and the Detroit producer’s disillusionment of the city’s musical legacy, while mentioning that many of the tracks on *Techno!* were recorded at United Sound Studios—often credited as “Techno Sound Lab”—where Motown producer and songwriter Don Davis worked with artists like the Dramatics, George Clinton, The Dells, and David Ruffin.[75] Likewise, Eddie Fowlkes contemplated the period of time after Motown “left and took the whole structure of Detroit music with them. They left a vacuum that has taken over 15 years to fill.”[76] Yet, despite Cosgrove’s knee-jerk assumption of European influence, the artists who created techno were part of a resilient cultural moment in Detroit from 1972 to 1987 as the population of the city flipped into a Black working-class majority alongside the city’s decline into a post-industrial phase rife with economic lows and high unemployment. Members of the House, a Berry Gordy-inspired production group led by Mike Banks, told Cosgrove that “Techno is about simplicity. We don’t want to compete with Jimmy Jam and Terry Lewis. Modern R&B has too many rules: big snare sounds, big bass, and even bigger studio bills.”[77] Earlier in the article still, Cosgrove talks with Juan Atkins in his basement studio space in West Detroit. Atkins built on Mike Banks’s intuition not to follow the blueprint of Black popular culture and standardization of commercial music, summarizing: “Within the last 5 years or so, the Detroit underground has been experimenting with technology, stretching it rather than simply using it. As the price of sequencers and synthesizers has dropped, the experimentation became more intense. Basically, we're tired of hearing about being in love or falling out, tired of the R&B system, so a new progressive sound has emerged. We call it techno!”[78]

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[74] Derrick May, quoted in Cosgrove, Ibid., PAGE.
[75] Alongside working on Motown’s first ever hit record Barrett Strong’s “Money (That’s What I Want)” in 1959 and Parliament’s *The Mothership Connection* in 1975, Don Davis purchased and grew First Independence Bank, the twelfth largest African American-owned bank in the US. See Alan Hughes, “First Independence's Sweet Song of Growth,” Black Enterprise, March 1, 2010, https://www.blackenterprise.com/first-independence%E2%80%99s-sweet-song-of-growth/?test=prebid.
[76] Eddie Folkes, quoted in Cosgrove, Ibid., PAGE.
[77] Members of the House, quoted in Cosgrove, Ibid., PAGE.
[78] Juan Atkins, quoted in Cosgrove, Ibid., PAGE.

2. Drifting Into a Time of No Future

"To visualize the future role of Negroes in a cybernated society, one must review, if only briefly, their past role in American society and what this means at the present stage of industrial development."
—James Boggs, *The Negro and Cybernation*[79]

"Unlike any nation in Europe, the United States holds whiteness as the unifying force. Here, for many people, the definition of 'Americanness' is color."
—Toni Morrison, "Making America White Again"[80]

"Contrary to popular belief, Negroes are the only substantial minority group in America who have a culture to guard and protect. The small, but crucial retentions of African tradition, the slavery experience, the post-slavery history of oppression, the reemergence of the non-white world, and America's refusal until recently to allow integration—all have combined, for better or for worse, to give the Negro a different reality, a different culture with which to master that reality, and a unique perspective by incongruity on American society that may be this nation's outstanding and redeeming virtue."
—Charles Keil, *Urban Blues*[81]

As he walks beside a graffiti-covered concrete Berlin Wall and scrolls past empty lots and demolished buildings, Blake Baxter—"the Prince of Techno"—describes the function of sampling and how it changed over the years, after techno traveled to Europe. Sampling, for Baxter, is a way for frequencies to come together to "honestly compose music" and harmonize a new sound: "Now, everyone samples from Detroit style stuff, or they mimic and copy, and a lot of these artists are making a killing off of it."[82] Baxter explains that techno began to slip away from its Detroit originators in part because of a gap in access to technology and equipment: "We don't have the studios or the money to come across as loud and as strong as the people who copy or are influenced by our music."[83] *Universal Techno*, a documentary produced in 1996 by French-German public television service ARTE, features such players—from the Belleville Three to Aphex Twin to LFO—across numerous interviews, attempting a historicization of techno and rave culture as a form of global collaboration.[84] As one of the oldest artifacts of the dance music phenomenon, *Universal Techno* documents their first encounters with rave culture and offers a pre-global oral history of techno's origins in Detroit through detailed discussion of the

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[79] James Boggs, "The Negro and Cybernation," in *The Evolving Society: The First Conference on the Cyberculture Revolution—Cybernetics and Automation* (New York: The Institute for Cybercultural Research, 1966), 168.
[80] Toni Morrison, "Making America White Again," *The New Yorker*, November 21, 2016, https://www.newyorker.com/magazine/2016/11/21/making-america-white-again
[81] Charles Keil, *Urban Blues* (Chicago: Chicago University Press, 1991), 191.
[82] Blake Baxter, interviewed in Universal Techno
[83] Blake Baxter, Ibid.
[84] *Universal Techno,* directed by Dominique Deluze, Super 16mm film, 1:02:24, produced by Les Fil à Lou and La Sept ARTE, 1996. ARTE was founded in 1991 as a joint European venture that sought to broadcast programming which could "bring French and German citizens closer on a cultural level and promote cultural integration throughout Europe."

socio-economic conditions of ’80s Detroit and its influence on key figures of the movement’s interpretative use of music technology. [85]

In the next scene, the voice of Jonathan Fleming, author of the 1995 visual history of raving, *What Kind of House Party Is This?* narrates an over the shoulder shot as he flips through a magazine featuring the Belleville Three. His succinct, culturally distant portrayal of each of their contributions to techno assumed that, “Since these people were being influenced by Kraftwerk, this has become not a culture or a community in Germany, but a life thing. That is why there is such a passion for techno music in Germany as opposed to anywhere else in the world.”[86] The Belleville Three, too, appear each in turn. In a confessional-style scene earlier in the film, Juan Atkins sits in a studio, recounting how he came to produce music at the age of seventeen: “I knew that I wanted to make a record, but that was the extent of my dream at the moment. To have it played and to have people hear it.”[87] He had no idea that the music would travel to Europe and proliferate the world.[88] A discussion of Kevin Saunderson’s vocal house project, Innercity—the release that brought techno to the masses—follows. Two of Inner City’s songs, “Big Fun” and “Good Life,” were crossover hits in both the dance and pop markets. Later in the documentary, Saunderson is shown at the Detroit offices of the label Submerge Recordings, pulling and playing his remix of Underground Resistance’s first release, “Living for the Night,” featuring vocalist Yolanda Reynolds—which he called one of his favorite remix jobs. Bringing up the Electrifying Mojo, Saunderson explains how the show would air at midnight and play music that was different from any of the commercial hits programmed during the day: “All of these mixed sounds, which was never heard before until he came on definitely had a lot to do with the inspiration in Detroit.”[89]

Derrick May, who is referred to earlier in the film as “the crazy man of the group,” talks about his understanding of machinery, electronics, and industry. He explains his decision to transition from DJing to experimenting with electronic instruments after watching Atkins build a relationship with his machines over the years—a direct affront to their typically cold, industrial working-class environment. “Machines have no love nor any feeling, and sometimes the people that work for these machines end up having no feeling nor love because they’re working relentless hours, they’re putting in total commitment to something that is giving nothing back.”[90] As a DJ, May developed a philosophy of “making music with music records,” which would carry over into his music productions. “We took these same ideas of machinery—not necessarily the synthesizer, but it was more or less the *sound* of the synthesizer—that we created our own sounds, and all these sounds subconsciously came from the idea of industry….” For *Universal Techno*, he takes the camera crew to the Michigan Theater, an abandoned 4,038-seat French Renaissance-style establishment built in downtown Detroit in 1925 by the infamous sibling architects, Cornelius W. and George L. Rappas: “Inside this building was a theater, and they tore out the theater and

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[85] Baxter, Ibid.
[86] Jonathan Fleming, interviewed in *Universal Techno*, Ibid.
[87] Juan Atkins, interviewed in *Universal Techno,* Ibid.
[88] Atkins, Ibid.
[89] Kevin Saunderson, interviewed in *Universal Techno*, Ibid
[90] Derrick May, interviewed in *Universal Techno,* Ibid.

they made a car park."[91] "I don't feel sad, I feel angry. Angry at stupid people," Derrick notes, comparing Detroit to the Titanic—it's "only above water"—a compendious remark that evokes a trend of arrogant exuberance in American utopian thinking, which inevitably leads to great catastrophe. "In America, nobody cares about these things... People in America tend to let this shit die, let it go with no sort of respect for history."[92] Despite being a controversial figure in techno for his pointed quips, unsavory womanizing antics, and impassioned improvisational lectures on the arts and all things romantic in the world, May was attuned to the unsustainability of Detroit's design ventures and global exports:

> […] [B]eing a techno-electronic-futurist, high-tech musician, I totally believe in the future, but I also believe in a historic and well-kept past. I believe that there are some things that are important. Now maybe this is more important like this, because in this atmosphere, you can realize just how much people don't care, how much they don't respect—and it can make you realize how much you should respect.[93]

In yet another scene of side-scrolling through aged and neglected houses and corner stores in Detroit, the camera draws visual connections with the previous shot of the Berlin Wall. "Detroit, probably as you've noticed, is somewhat of a depressed postindustrial city, and I think that the general attitude here with the powers that be, with the government, with the local government is that, you know, industry must die to make way for technology. I think Detroit is a city in North America that's probably experienced the technological revolution first, and I think that it affects all of the occupants of Detroit, including the artists, the musicians and what have you." Having coined the term "techno" from his own readings of Alvin Toffler, Atkins reflected that, "The climate has definitely affected us, and I think ... we probably wouldn't have developed this sound in any other city in America other than Detroit, and that's the major reason why I stay here and I haven't moved…." He concludes: "There is a certain atmosphere here that you can't find in any other city that lends to the technological movement."[94]

A generation before the Black youth of Detroit harnessed the machine soul of techno, political activist and autoworker James Boggs foresaw the automation of labor, sharing Atkins and May's sentiments about the conditions of their city. James Boggs migrated from Alabama to Detroit in the 1940s, leaving behind the sharecropper labor and white supramicist violence of the Deep South for salaried job opportunities at the auto factories of Detroit. That very experience led to his involvement in political activism. His writings alone and in collaboration with his partner, Grace Lee, challenged mainstream notions of labor rights and revolution, and theorized the unraveling society at the center of the American industrial empire that had formed in the wake of the Second World War. In 1964, Boggs spoke at the First Annual Conference on the Cybercultural Revolution–Cybernetics and Automation, centering on the theme of "The Evolving Society." His paper, "Negro and Cybernation," expressed a concern for the Black people like himself, who had migrated from the militarized white supremacist oppression of the American

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[91] Derrick May, Ibid.
[92] May, *Ibid.*
[93] May, Ibid.
[94] Juan Atkins, Ibid.

South to the labor and class struggles of the industrial- and corporate-run northern states in the 1930s and 1940s. He wrote:

> In each industry where machinery played this vital rôle [sic], the Negro played a special rôle [sic]—that of being the last to be recruited and usually only on an emergency basis, *e.g.*, war. Only in agriculture was he the first mass force. Elsewhere he has been relegated to the most menial, manual labor under the worst conditions, *e.g.*, foundry, pick and shovel in the mines, rolling mills, furnace rooms, janitors, material handlers. Thus, in the work process, within American society, the rôle [sic] of the Negro has been that of the scavenger. He got the jobs which white Americans would not do, which they considered beneath their dignity, which they had abandoned, or in dying industries.[95]

The United States' transition from chattel to wage slavery was a slow, multi-decade process, unfolding from the 1880s to the 1950s. "Today," Boggs remarked, "very few college-trained whites are going into these civil and social service jobs. Instead they are going into scientific research and development-for industry, for government—on the basis of the new and highly developed technological level of modern industry. Meanwhile, few Negroes are being admitted into these fields except on a token basis." The plantation industry of the Confederacy in the American South served as an initial means of mechanization against the ecosystem to develop a flowing economy, utilizing African American slave labor and eugenic breeding to significantly increase the rate of production. At the beginning of the nineteenth century, America began to shift gears from being an enticing blank slate of available resources for the colonial project to symbolizing an obelisk of production and security for the select few. The United States "victory" in the Mexican American War also resulted in the genocide of over seventy distinct groups of Native Americans. After the financial crisis of 1837, the United States sought relief from the economic panic, which lasted until the discovery of gold in California. The Mexican American War and gold rush of the mid-1800s simultaneously spurred national economic growth and established multiple states within the grasp of the Greater United States. In 1848, news of gold in California reached Michigan, just as a major presidential election was taking place, pinning Detroit's Democratic candidate, Lewis Cass against Whig Party candidate, Zachary Taylor. Following Cass's loss, the Michigan newspapers began to devote less non-advertising space to politics, switching focus to commissioned accounts of gold discoveries. These articles encouraged locals to venture out West to see if they could also acquire some amount of gold and bring wealth to Detroit. This was in effect America's first "get rich quick" scheme, marking the beginning of the nation's draw towards infinite economic growth and its individualist approach to community development.

Despite a complete system collapse, the US was able to ride out the economic deflation and extended depression which lasted from 1837 to 1842, rebounding after the discovery and distribution of gold as a unit of measurable value in 1848.[96] Production on the railroad system increased to accommodate the influx of new land and wealth as well as the mass of people

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[95] Boggs, "The Negro and Cybernation," 169.
[96] Robert Whaples, "California Gold Rush," EH.net Encyclopedia, ed.Robert Whaples, March 16, 2008, http://eh.net/encyclopedia/california-gold-rush/.

crossing the country to gain access to the newest US acquisition. Transcontinental travel in the US became a way to maintain control and easily transfer resources during this economic boom. Unlike the Roman Empire, in which all roads lead back to Rome, the US seemed to wrap the whole of the North American territory in its draining tentacles. Now in full swing, the industrial revolution yielded a large supply of oil and metal materials, transported from extraction sites and city centers via newly-built railroads. As technology and materials became more and more accessible, the economic upswing also shifted the established class structure of the developing United States. Manual labor became much easier to perform with the assistance of novel though crude work-in-progress inventions of the 1800s, ushering in the transition into the twentieth century. Technological updates and a burgeoning concept of man-machine relations lessened the need for slave labor on a national scale, with newly landed immigrants from China and Ireland providing cheap and more humanized labor. America lurched forward to a prime moment of rapid advancement into automation and cybernetics. A once large mass of land made up of singular clusters of cities and states could now sift resources domestically, on a free market.

In the 1800s, at the peak of the Antebellum-era South, a large portion of the US economy and production was upheld by Africans imported and sold in the transatlantic slave trade.[97] In the Confederacy, an aristocracy of slave owners who ran plantations with over fifty slaves was consolidated, and gained political influence in the process. The pre-Antebellum South had a relatively weak economy due to widespread anti-industrial and -technological sentiment. States in the Black Belt, a large geological region with rich soil stretching from central Alabama to northern Mississippi, made for an ideal place to forge an agricultural revolution against the technological one mounting in the United Kingdom and, by proxy, the Union of the northern states.[98] Heavily reliant on the physical labor of African American slaves, the Antebellum South plantation complex cultivated cotton, grain, tobacco, sugar, and rice—base materials in the global industrial economy. Plantation economies greatly impacted the structural integrity of the natural ecosystem of the South. In some ways, the plantation modeled the beginnings of big business as a general threat to the planet itself, let alone the millions of West Africans forced into physical labor. Within and around the Antebellum plantations, armed forces, including but not limited to the police, military, and armed citizens enclosed people, machines and natural resources that are considered non-human.

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[97] “When the rulers of the Old South ‘calculated the value of the Union’, one of their prime considerations was the question of slave control. Some felt that it was not wise to repudiate a constitution which provided for the assistance of the entire nation, if needed, to suppress an insurrection; others, that secession, even if peaceably accomplished, would accentuate the discontent of the Negros, and if resulting in war, would certainly have that effect and thus weaken the South.” Herbert Aptheker, *American Negro Slave Revolts* (New York: International Publishers, 1970), 34-36.

[98] “There are 12 counties in Alabama in each of which the Blacks are twice as numerous as the whites. These 12 counties, stretching across southern Central Alabama from Georgia and Mississippi, constitute the principal portion of the famous Black Belt…the counties in which there are few Negros are the portions of the state in which the soil is comparatively sterile, and inhabited largely by small white farmers, the conditions of whose lives are now hard as they always have been, and who have a hereditary jealousy of the richer planters and of the town’s populations.” "Politics and the Race Question in Alabama, *The Nation* 59, no. 1525 (September 20, 1894): 211-212.

In the 1800s, Detroit became an important stop along the Underground Railroad, which slaves traveled to run away from bondage in the plantation industrial complex of the Southern states. Intersecting between at least seven routes, Detroit and the Black churches and communities that would settle there were social and economic generators, previously doubling as safe havens for runaway slaves.[99] Black migration patterns from the 1940s to the 1960s would retrace these routes, soon to be further amplified by job growth, as deskilled and routinized workflow processes were becoming a production standard for employing workers with little to no expertise.[100] Detroit's early-twentieth-century labor, economic, and population boom resonated throughout the surrounding Midwestern states due to the invention and production of the automobile, which linked together cities and citizens more effectively than the railroads that had initially unified the disparate American regions and territories. The progressive, multi-century-long invention of the modern automobile[101] gained traction in the United States, beginning with the creation of the luxury car company, Cadillac in 1902.[102] The following year, the industrialist businessman Henry Ford, the "richest man in the world," founded the Ford Motor Company with the intention of optimizing manufacturing, according to the production model of the assembly line, a lean process that allowed Ford's factory to employ and train mostly unskilled workers to build cars both quickly and at low cost, while paying them enough to be able to afford the car itself and make "a decent living." "Fordism" designated a prescription for high efficiency in worker production, ensuring quick profit turnaround by accelerating the movement and decisive settling of Americans in the area. Ford Motors' cheap and efficient update of the automobile, combined with its implementation of the conveyor belt "assembly line" production model, ensured that Detroit—home to the three largest automobile manufacturers in the country—became one its leading financial centers. Moreover, the Ford business model established organized and streamlined productivity in the factory and office divisions and standardized labor practices and manufacturing processes in the global industry,[103] triggering a shift in workforce development from slave to wage labor[104] and introduced a distinction between white-collar and blue-collar work. "The white-collar people slipped quietly into modern society," writes American sociologist C. Wright Mills in the introduction to his 1951 book *White Collar: The*

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[99] Boyd, *Black Detroit*, 35-42.

[100] Isabel Wilkerson, "The Long-Lasting Legacy of the Great Migration," Smithsonian Magazine, September 2016,
https://www.smithsonianmag.com/history/long-lasting-legacy-great-migration-180960118/.

[101] Nicolas-Joseph Cugnot in France, Robert Anderson in Scotland, Karl Friedrich Benz, Gottlieb Wilhelm Daimler and Wilhelm Maybach in Germany as well as George Baldwin Selden, Charles Edgar Duryea and his brother Frank in the United States
https://www.loc.gov/everyday-mysteries/item/who-invented-the-automobile/

[102] Named for Detroit's founder, Antoine de la Mothe Cadillac.
Boyd, Herb, Black Detroit, 2017

[103] Nicola Pizzolato, "The Making and Unmaking of Fordism," in *Challenging Global Capitalism: Labor, Migration, Radical Struggle, and Urban Change in Detroit and Turin* (New York: Palgrave Macmillan, 2013), 19-45.

[104] Near the end of the First World War, Henry Ford was the biggest employer of Black people, offering a wage of five dollars a day rather than the standard of five dollars a month but as Herb Boyd notes: "These future workers were not aware that one of Ford's motives for five-dollar-a-day pay was to impede the growth and effectiveness of the Industrial Workers of the World and the Communist Party. Offering workers what he viewed as a decent salary would, he hoped, be incentive enough to keep them from the pull of an alternative economic system. Nor did these workers know or care about Ford's racial ambivalence." Boyd, *Black Detroit*, 92-93.

American Middle Classes.[105] Mills studied social alienation in the modernizing New World, and argued that the United States was becoming a society of employees. He wrote of the rise of technicians who operate and manage varying levels of bureaucratic tasks within a corporate entity. Employed to maintain and upgrade the technocracy from within, the technician, for Mills, is a person who has "ceased to be in any sense a free intellectual"; the "good-willed" technician's self-image has become "more solidly middle class, a man at a desk, married, with children, living in a respectable suburb, his career pivoting on the selling of ideas, his life a tight little routine, substituting middle-brow and mass culture for direct experience of his life and his world, and, above all, becoming a man with a job in a society where money is supreme."[106] The concept of status and social hierarchy, alongside the necessities of food, shelter, and community, form a desperate simulation, now the norm for a new kind of an industrial middle class. Mills pointedly refers to it as "the morale of the cheerful robots":

> Management effort to create job enthusiasm reflects the unhappy unwillingness of employees to work spontaneously at their routinized tasks; it indicates recognition of the lack of spontaneous will to work for the ulterior ends available; it also indicates that it is more difficult to have happy employees when the chances to climb the skill and social hierarchies are slim.[107]

White collar labor's incisive critique of workplace management offers greater perspective on aspects of the average American's style of living; understanding of power, ideology, value; and overall built environment, would be aggressively uprooted and transformed for the needs of corporate expansion and governmental oversight of bureaucratic and economic projects. Mills' reference to white-collar unionism, highlights a fault line between technical workers in the office and those who perform physical, manual, and infrastructural tasks out in society—blue collar workers. In a technocratic society—and in spite of the United State's' agricultural beginnings—jobs in government, entertainment, and communications industries that directly advance a company's economic growth are deemed far more valuable than the work that is done to maintain the essential functions of the very society in which the technocrats and their white collar class live.

But a decade earlier, the claims for the advanced mechanization of society through industrialization still held strong. In 1963, *Monthly Review Press* published a humble and impassioned document of general thoughts and revolutionary provisions for workers and foreign policy by Boggs, titled "The American Revolution: Pages from a Negro Worker's Notebook." Boggs drew on his experiences as an assembly line worker at a Detroit Chrysler automotive plant in this tract, which he opened with the following remarks: "I am a factory worker, but I know more than just factory work,"[108] echoing Mills' acknowledgement of the employee's unwilling enthusiasm for work in an industrial society:

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[105] C. Wright Mills, *White Collar: The American Middle Classes* (Oxford:: Oxford University Press, 1951), ix.
[106] Mills, *White Collar*, 156.
[107] Mills, 233.
[108] James Boggs, "The American Revolution: Pages from a Negro Workers' Notebook," *Monthly Review Press* (1963): 11.

> I know the difference between what would sound right if one lived in a society of logical people and what *is* right when you live in a society of real people with real differences. It may sound perfectly natural to a highly educated and logical person, even when he hears people saying that there is going to be a big riot, to assume that there will not be a big riot because authorities have everything under control. But if *I* kept hearing people say that there was going to be a big riot and I saw one of these logical people standing in the middle, I would tell him he'd better get out of the way because he sure was going to get killed.[109]

Boggs discusses labor unions, which "manufactured a new definition of democracy; the holding of one election after another until the workers vote the way the union wants them to vote."[110] Collapsing twenty years of labor union conflicts against corporate capitalists into twenty pages, Boggs established a firmly post-Marxist stance on class struggle by detailing the specificity of the Black population's position within the United States' history of labor management systems, as a newly integrated working class born to former government-sanctioned slaves.[111] In a word, Boggs's musings could be extrapolated into roles assigned to the labor management structure of the United States' recent past, by considering company executives as comparable to plantation owners; unions as akin to slave drivers; and workers—both white and blue collar with respectively divergent experiences—as fulfilling the lowest roles of house and field slave laborers. Migrating to Detroit in 1937, Boggs, the son of an Alabama sharecropper, hitchhiked and rode trains northward in flight from the racial violence and mandated segregation between white and Black communities that was legally instituted across the Southern states. The state of Louisiana, for instance, passed the Separate Car Act in 1890, allowing train companies to seat and separate riders according to color.[112] In 1892, Homer Plessy, a Louisiana resident, legally challenged the constitutionality of the law based on his own ancestral heritage of being "seven-eighths white" and "one-eighth Black" in the *Plessy v. Ferguson* case, which circulated through multiple courts before landing in front of the US Supreme Court, which chose to uphold existing law. While the Fourteenth Amendment granted equality between white and Black Americans it did not, the Supreme Court ruled, legally protect from social and governmental "distinctions based upon color."

In the Gilded Age that spanned from the 1870s to the early 1900s, the Northern and Western states experienced economic growth and connectivity, while the Antebellum South would sink

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[109] Boggs, "The American Revolution," 11.
[110] Ibid., 26.
[111] "Under these circumstances, what shall we say of the Marxian philosophy and of its relation to the American Negro? We can only say, as it seems to me, the Marxian philosophy is a true diagnosis of the situation in Europe in the middle of the 19th Century despite some of its logical difficulties. But it must be modified in the United States of America and especially so far as the Negro group is concerned. The Negro is exploited to a degree that means poverty, crime, delinquency and indigence. And that exploitation comes not from a black capitalistic class but from the white capitalists and equally from the white proletariat." W.E.B. Du Bois, "Marxism and the Negro Problem," *The Crisis* 40, no. 5 (May 1933): 104.
[112] Supreme Court of The United States. U.S. Reports: Plessy v. Ferguson, 163 U.S. 537. 1895. Periodical. https://www.loc.gov/item/usrep163537/.

into economic depression from the impact of the Civil War, in the process stripping Black people of their political rights to create a firm separation and financial independence from freed slaves.[113] The second Industrial Revolution taking place in America led to an expansion in the British textile industry, increasing demand for cotton. American production and distribution became increasingly addicted to potency and dependent on satisfaction with the acceleration of technology and the type of aggressive capitalism that was forming out of the universal desperation to remain in a state of independence. “As slavery rapidly entrenched itself in the plantation colonies during the early years of the eighteenth century, it forced English colonists to come to grips with novel problems which arose from the very nature of the institution,” writes Winthrop D. Jordan, a historian of slavery and the origins of racism in the United States in his 1974 book *The White Man’s Burden*. “Plainly, Negro slaves were propetry in a sense not thoroughtly comprehended by traditional English concepts and legal categories.”[114] Jordan’s study analyzes how white American attitudes towards Black people would go on to frame the American native inhabitants as “Indians,” and model the construction and understanding of other categories of racial minorities in the labor, class, and economic system of American society and government. “The spectre of Negro rebellion presented an appalling world turned upside down, a crazy nonsense world of Black over white, an anti-community which was the direct negation of the community as white men knew it.”[115] Chronicling the social and intellectual development of American nationalism and culture after the revolution and established constitution in 1776, Jordan detects a legal and political bias that “the postwar need for strong unified government tempted Americans to emphasize the nation’s unity even to the point of utterly ignoring existing diversities,” such that American culture became an architectural device that could modify and create a “new man” from a European and their descendents. Jordan’s study would conclude: “Presumably the Negro is not an American.”[116]

The four-hundred-year saga of West African–now Black–insurrection in the American South was drastically redefined from the late nineteenth through to the mid-twentieth century. In the South, the Jim Crow laws enacted by a Democrat-led state legislature would establish racial segregation as a social and legal standard of living while leaving little protection for Black people against the domestic white terrorism that emerged during Reconstruction. Before 1910, 90% of the Black population lived in the American South, but migration to the North became widespread, leaving behind one kind of white supremacist disenfranchisement in the form of lynchings, house bombings, and legal restrictions on voting rights only to find the brewing class and labor struggles of the urban industrial complexes upon arrival.[117] On June 20, 1943, a riot broke out in Detroit—spurred by pre-existing tensions over the migrating Black population and subsequent concerns from the white population about job and housing shortages—when assembly line jobs required the two groups to work alongside one another. The final toll left 34

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[113] William Strauss and Neil Howe, Generations: The History of America’s Future 1584-2069, 206-207
[114] Winthorp D. Jordan, *The White Man’s Burden: Historical Origins of Racism in the United States* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1974), 59.
[115] Jordan, 62-64.
[116] Ibid., 133.
[117] Census, United States Bureau of the (July 23, 2010). “Migrations – The African-American Mosaic Exhibition – Exhibitions (Library of Congress).” www.loc.gov.

dead, 433 injured, and 1,800 arrested.[118] In the following decade, the racial crisis widened as the relationship between unions and Black workers dissolved in favor of Ford's paternalistic social welfare services, even as the city of Detroit saw great economic growth through a wave of company mergers, and the formation of an oligopoly—an industry dominated by a small group of sellers and distributors. The Fordist method of business and labor management greatly improved and set a standard for productivity in the US industrial labor market, but Ford's ideology for a fine-tuned and streamlined economic and social system set a pace of living that would accelerate modern convenience while reducing the number of workers and materials necessary to produce sellable goods. The lean margins of Ford's assembly line and salary-based labor framework hinged on the three principles of synchronization, precision, and specialization—in comparison to Toffler's six principles of product and demographic programmability: standardization, specialization, synchronization, concentration, maximization, and centralization.[119] When set in motion, Ford's utopian vision for a labor management system tailored the manufacturing process to the relationship between the worker and the machine: both would labor together in cybernetic harmony, with the worker contributing to every task towards the final step of the process in every task—a gesture of human dominance in project management and intellectual capability that ensured that the worker felt needed.

"Automation is a change in the mode of production which is more radical than any since the introduction of the assembly line," Boggs wrote in the second chapter of "The American Revolution," forecasting that the lean production schemes which ran Detroit would become even leaner by relying more heavily on automated machinery.[120] In the same way, it had seemed that the technocrats had suddenly surged forward into a future without its core labor force and partial consumer. Motioning for an empathy for human value, Boggs describes the blue-collar class as living, feeling people who have wants and desires that are unfortunately strung up in the "stuff of reality"—commodities in a capitalist industrial society.[121] He notes that working people labor to maintain their class status and the "personal things" they have invested their hard-earned money into, at the expense of noticing the looming potential for mass unemployment, let alone organizing around it. The personal crisis of one's standard of living concerned Boggs: corporations were an essential life force for workers, but the recent introduction of automation optimized manufacturing processes beyond the need for workers, and the government, a burgeoning moralist capitalist empire, offered little in the way of welfare.

In "The American Revolution," Boggs provided an evolutionary theory extending far beyond Karl Marx's increasingly outdated understanding of industrial production and economics. Considering where the United States began and where it was heading, he wrote that "American Marxists have tended to fall into the trap of thinking of the Negroes as Negroes, i.e., in race terms, when in fact the Negroes have been and are today the most oppressed and submerged sections of the workers, on whom has fallen most sharply the burden of unemployment due to

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[118] Boyd, *Black Detroit,* 150-154.
[119] Alvin Toffler, *The Third Wave*, 62-73.
[120] Boggs, "The American Revolution," 23.
[121] Ibid., 33-36.

automation."[122] Declaring the United States a "warfare state" and "the citadel of world capitalism today,"[123] rather than the manufactured reality being sold to US citizens through big box stores, mail-order catalogs, and the media, Boggs pointed to the larger postwar context: the United States was the only nation worldwide to ever weaponize nuclear warheads, dropping two nuclear bombs on Hiroshima and Nagasaki, Japan, and killing close to 140,000 and 74,000, in each city.[124] For Boggs, the society the United States had built was based on a class system that had extracted its wealth from an unpaid, unwilling, slave population violently forced to relocate across the grand continent of the Americas to secure and maintain the white colonizer's comfort. As civil rights leaders and supporters of a new and much needed Black nationalist ideology protested and opposed the opaque legal status of being relegated to the category of second-class citizens in a nation full of workers and immigrants, white people and private and governing institutions responded by urging the oppressed to assimilate, scale the ranks of the capitalist utopia of their oppressors, and exploit others within a government-sanctioned, hierarchical, socioeconomic game.

In his worker's notes, Boggs struggled to respond with any positivity to the instrumentalization of enforced Black integration within the unveiled farce of American democracy, lamenting and speaking out against how Black citizens were left out of the socioeconomic benefits of the New Deal following the Great Depression: "The right to live has always been so tied up with the necessity to produce that it is hard for the average person to visualize a workless society."[125] Workless in this sense implies a present state in which Americans are free to experience life while endowed with the support of governing institutions, without the reciprocity of indentured labor—working for the right to live in a country that often doesn't pay its Black citizens equitably. "To this day, the American nation celebrates the Civil War and records it as a war to free the slaves," Boggs stated, retracing the history of race-based labor movements and uprisings. He settled on an understanding of the Black population as "outsiders," "rebels with a cause" whose physical and existential contributions to the foundations of the United States held no value. Rather, "in the eyes of Negroes the Civil War was the war which made it possible for the United States to be industrialized, the war which resulted in the Bargain of 1877 between Northern capital and Southern landed aristocracy, which left the former slaves living and working under a caste system as brutal as that of slavery itself."[126]

In "The Challenge Facing Afro-Americans in the 1980s," a 1979 speech delivered at the Center for Afro-American and African Studies at the University of Michigan, Boggs spoke about the considerable rise in the possibility of an African Americans middle class after the passing of the Civil Rights Act of 1964, describing the ontological social construct of racism as "the principal and fundamental contradiction of American society." He reasoned that if the contradiction of a racial caste system within the American free market Republic was resolved, Black people

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[122] Ibid., 85.
[123] Ibid., 42.
[124] Seren Morris, "How Many People Died in Hiroshima and Nagasaki?" *Newsweek*, August 3, 2020, https://www.newsweek.com/how-many-people-died-hiroshima-nagasaki-japan-second-world-war-1522276.
[125] Boggs, "The American Revolution," 46.
[126] Ibid., 75.

"would no longer be systematically relegated to the bottom of society, we would no longer feel inferior to other Americans, and we would be free to pursue happiness as we saw other Americans pursuing it all around us." He continued:

> Until a few years ago Blacks were very critical of the individualistic and materialistic values of white Americans because it was so obvious that the high standard of living enjoyed by white Americans was largely at the expense of Blacks and other people of color. The Black community prided itself on the trust and respect that Blacks had for one another, contrasting it with the way that whites would do anything for a buck. However, since the barriers of racism have been lifted to let Blacks into the system, the individualistic and materialistic values that were always at the heart of the American Dream have become as much a part of Black relationships as they are of the relationships among other Americans.[127]

W. E. B. Du Bois' writing in *Black Reconstruction in America* contemplated the placement of the Black worker in the United States of America in the century preceding Boggs, between the years of 1860 to 1880: "Easily the most dramatic episode in American history was the sudden move to free four million Black slaves in an effort to stop a great civil war, to end forty years of bitter controversy, and to appease the moral sense of civilization."[128] The nonliterate slave population, "whose languages, and therefore whose cultural and traditional histories, are not written"—Amiri Baraka described in his 1963 history of Negro music in white America, *Blues People*—stood as "the antithesis of Western man and his highly industrialized civilization."[129] Baraka asserted that the ethnic material simmering within the Negro slave population came from a philosophical substance and system that was alien to the Western world and the American nationalist ideology. "Afro-Americans (by whom I mean the first few generations of American-born Black people, who still retained a great many *pure* Africanisms), and later, American Negroes, inherited all these complexities with, of course, whatever individual nuances were dictated by their particular lives," Baraka insisted that, "the ugly fact that the Africans were forced into an alien world where none of the references or cultural shapes of any familiar human attitudes were available is the determinant of the *kind* of existence they had to eke out here: not only slavery itself but the particular circumstances in which it existed."[130]

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[127] Boggs, "The Challenge Facing Afro-Americans in the 1980s," in *Pages from a Black Radical's Notebook: A James Boggs Reader*, ed. Stephen M. Ward (Detroit, Wayne State University, 2011), 309.
[128] W.E.B. Du Bois, *Black Reconstruction in America 1860-1880* (New York: Free Press, 1998), 3 (See also: 1860 Census)
[129] Amiri Barka, *The Blues People* (Harper Perennial, 1963), 6-8.
[130] Baraka, Ibid.

Enduring rigorous work schedules, poor quality of life and food,[131] slaves surfaced new vocalized sounds in their songs.[132] The workers sang communally, expressing their hopes for a better future and the sorrows of a hellish present. Coded messages were interwoven within these songs, creating a multi-directional, stereophonic communication system using voice and drum.[133] Spiritual hymns are in effect a cultural divergence, the beginning of a multi-century process of West African slaves converging into an existential socio-economic "Black," further subdivided into a gradient genetic hierarchy of Negro, mulatto, quadroon, octroon, etc.[134] Under the management of their masters, slaves adapted the syncopated beats and dances on the slave ships as they crossed over from Africa to the New World, giving rise to professional forms of entertainment, like the spectacle of Thomas "Blind Tom" Higgins, an enslaved multi-instrumentalist child prodigy, promoted as the "Wonder of the World."[135] The twentieth-century child of a Georgia slave, Blind Tom made his masters a fortune by performing and touring America and Europe, while being kept uncompensated for decades both before and after the Emancipation Proclamation was passed in 1863.[136] Over time, however, such songs developed into a Black secret technological language for altering reality and making objects, machines, and even environments speak. From the depths of blackness, a hue of blues would emerge through personal songs and call-and-response vocalizations—consider the rebellion led by the enslaved preacher Nat Turner, who mobilized songs to signal and coordinate on-the-ground warfare.[137]

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[131] "I cannot remember a single instance during my childhood or early boyhood when our entire family sat down to the table together, and God's blessing was asked, and the family ate a meal in a civilized manner. On the plantation in Virginia, and even later, meals were gotten by the children very much as dumb animals get theirs. It was a piece of bread here and a scrap of meat there. It was a cup of milk at one time and some potatoes at another. Sometimes a portion of our family would eat out of the skillet or pot, while someone else would eat from a tin plate held on the knees, and often using nothing but the hands with which to hold the food." Booker T. Washington, *Up from Slavery: An Autobiography* (New York: Signet Classics, 2010), 6.

[132] "Black music is a bridge between elective muteness and the scream, between excess and disguise. Every variation of speech and speechlessness at our disposal begins as song. Every song pursues the silence after its last note. On the passage to that silence we encounter low hummed sounds, hysterical sounds, requiem sounds, healing sounds, masochistic sounds, unsounds, murmurs, and, in dire conditions, we refuse all sound and let the aura play its field around us, and suspense, menace, and near threat become the condition of our singing and our silence." Harmony Holiday, "The Black Catatonic Scream," Triple Canopy, August 20, 2020, https://www.canopycanopycanopy.com/contents/the-black-catatonic-scream

[133] "Antiphony (call and response) is the principal formal feature of these musical traditions. It has come to be seen as a bridge from music into other modes of cultural expression, supplying, along with improvisation, montage, and dramaturgy, the hermeneutic keys to the full medley of Black artistic practices." Paul Gilroy, *The Black Atlantic*, 78.

[134] Du Bois, *Black Reconstruction in America*, 3.

[135] Langston Hughes and Milton Meltzer, Black Magic: A Pictorial History of the African-American in the Performing Arts (New York: Da Capo Press, 1990), 7-15.

[136] Hughes and Meltzer, Ibid.

[137] Aptheker, *American Negro Slave Revolts*, 294-306. See also: Thomas R. . Gray, *The Confessions of Nat Turner* (Baltimore: Thomas R. Gray, 1831), 7, 11, 18; and Erik Nielson, "'Go in de Wilderness': Evading the 'Eyes of Others' in the Slave Songs," *Western Journal of Black Studies* 35, no. 2 (March 2011): 106–17.

Baraka points to the Blues as a social phenomenon born during a time of enslavement, but not because of slavery: "*Blues* means a Negro experience, it is the one music that Negro made that could not be transferred into a more general significance than the one the Negro gave it initially." The "work song or shout" comprised of few English words, and the conglomeration of syllabic vocalizations that were available, grew the Blues as a separate language, which after emancipation would take the form of a personal song for one's self rather than the intercommunal spirituals that forged a culture of solidarity between enslaved workers.[138] Canadian media theorist Marshall McLuhan was pre-eminently aware of this phenomenon of Black people taking and forging new outcomes from technology produced during the twentieth century, as evidenced in his 1968 book with graphic designer Quentin Fiore, *War and Peace in the Global Village*:

> The American Negro who has long coexisted with this literate culture especially feels anger when he gets "turned on," because he can see that the causes of his degradation are to be found in a technology that is now repudiated by his masters. When the electric age began to be felt during and after the First World War, the world of Negro jazz welled up to conquer the white. Jazz was a Negro product because it is directly related to speech rhythm rather than to any printed page or score.[139]

"[T]he conjoining of writing and sound has particular ramifications for Black cultural production, given the importance of orality as the major mode of cultural transmission in this temporal setting," writes Alexander G. Weheliye, who documents the concept of "grooves in sonic Afro-modernity" in his book *Phonographies*. "Because alphabetic writing was such an embattled terrain for Black subjects in nineteenth-century America, the phonograph did not cause the same anxieties in Black cultural discourses, and musical notation and writing were not necessarily understood as the most natural way of recording music."[140] He reasons that the invention of the phonograph in 1877 allowed for a kind of speaking beyond the written language—an extended, disembodied voice and vision, which could take the fractured African songs that had traveled the Atlantic three-hundred years prior and intercept and transcribe them as an ethnic, "non-American" material in the New World. Situating Du Bois as a scribe of "secular messianism," Weheliye paraphrases his chronology of Black culture, experience, and music as a phono-optical emulsion, a divine source, captured and distributed within the confines of an industrial technological Western colonial economy:

> As a result, these sanguine harmonies and melodies "poison" the body politic of U.S. national culture by suffusing it with other ways of becoming human, which is to say that Black subjectivity not only functions as a constitutive trace or outside of whiteness,

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[138] "Some of the work songs, for instance, use as their measure the grunt of a man pushing a heavy weight or the blow of a hammer against a stone to provide the metrical precision and rhythmical impetus behind the singer." Baraka, Ibid., 62-67.
[139] Marshall McLuhan and Quentin Fiore, War and Peace in the Global Village (New York: Batam Books, 1968), PAGE TK.
[140] Alexander Weheliye, *Phonographies: Grooves in Sonic Afro-Modernity* (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 2005), 36.

> reason, citizenship, full humanity, and so on, but as an event horizon for "human promise." Possibly, this is what Du Bois has in mind when writing "Negro blood has a message for the world." Here, poisoning and offering concoct an alchemic brew of Blackness—a pharmakon, as Plato and Derrida would call itthat recolors, via the sonic (the gift of song), the very grounds of Western modernity. In the end, double consciousness does not so much critique as gift (poison and bless) the disembodiment of vision and by extension the human in modernity in its excavation and ampli cation of aural materiality, the "tremulous treble and darkening bass" (Souls, 215) veiled by scopic racial formation, as it throws phono-optics into the mix of the phonographic grooves of sonic Afro-modernity.[141]

Black culture in the colonized, industrializing America began to absorb, hack, and reformat European constructions such as the Napoleonic military marching band style at the same time as Black cultural gatherings in New Orleans' Congo Square began to spread across the nation as minstrel "show" music, marketed as entertainment to white consumers.[142] Baraka felt that as Black workers emerged into freedom, continued racial segregation and social distancing had created seperate societies in which Black people as the national minority and former slave-class were vulnerable to being distorted into caricature. In addition to the invention of the phonograph, the Radio Acts of 1912 and 1927 created a national telebroacasting network that further captured and distributed Black music as "race music"[143] throughout the nation, establishing a superstructural "blues continuum," which Baraka would retrace in *Blues People* as the evolution of blues, the introduction of jazz, and the secularization of Black music as a whole in the period after emancipation. "By the time the large dance and show bands started to develop into jazz bands, the more autonomous blues forms had gone largely underground, and had returned, as it were, to be enjoyed by the *subculture* in which they were most functional as a collective expression," Baraka writes.[144] He considered the commercialization of Black music as a signifier of assimilation into the middle class American culture of the northern states and a distillation of the Negro spirit into a open access commodity.[145] "All these blues forms existed together in the cities; the phonograph record and later the radio helped push this blues continuum into all parts of the country" Baraka writes. The blues continuum displayed a potent form of "authenticity" that had been tamed into a "more easily *faked*" rhythm and blues structure made for the radio.[146] "By

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[141] Weheliye, 44.

[142] "It is essential to realize that minstrelsy was an extremely important sociological phenomenon in America. The idea of white men imitating, or caricaturing, what they consider certain generic characteristics of the Black man's life in America to entertain other white men is important if only because of the Negro's reaction to it. [...] The Black minstrel shows were also what might be called parodies, or exaggerations, of certain aspects of Negro life in America. But in one sense the colored minstrel was poking fun at himself, and in another and probably more profound sense he was poking fun at the white man." Weheliye, 70-85.

[143] "Race records, sound recordings of the early 20th century that were made exclusively by and for African Americans. The term is sometimes said to have been coined by Ralph S. Peer, who was then working for OKeh Records." Britannica, T. Editors of Encyclopaedia (2020, September 30). Race records. Encyclopedia Britannica. https://www.britannica.com/art/race-record

[144] Baraka, 166.

[145] Ibid.

[146] "The fragmentation and subdivision of Black music into an ever increasing proliferation of styles and genres which makes a nonsense of this polar opposition between progress and dilution has also

the forties, after the war had completely wiped out remaining 'race' record categories, the radio became the biggest disseminator of blues music."[147] The overall growth of the music and entertainment industries, Baraka argues, was hindered by the fact that "large white companies" couldn't maintain a profitable business model on the recording and exclusive ownership of Black music, because so many songs were being recorded and released within Black communities, where many signed artists lived and performed—the multi-million dollar recording industry of Old Hastings Street in Detroit stands as a perfect example of this phenomenon. For Baraka, "Rhythm & blues was a popularization, in a very limited sense, of the older blues forms, and in many cases merely a commercialization, but it was still an emotionally sound music. Its very vulgarity assured its meaningful emotional connection with people's lives."[148]

Comparatively, jazz musician and music historian Charles Keil classifies Black music according to three distinct categories of African American expression: "sacred music—spirituals, jubilees, and gospels; secular music—blues (country and urban) and most jazz before World World War II; 'art' music or jazz since 1945."[149] Rhythm & Blues, a term coined in 1948 by music journalist Jerry Wexler of *Billboard* magazine, was meant to replace the catch-all African American music genre of "race music" as a new secular and commercial Black music full of metropolitan emotions, unfamiliar to the rural and pre-industrialized Black communities centralized around the Black church. Soul music thereafter and into the Civil Rights and Black Power movements of the 1950s and '60s formed a two-pronged ritual and outlet for Black creative expression between the secular and spiritual. Keil notes that "Bluesmen and preachers both provide models and orientations; both give public expression to deeply felt private emotions; both promote catharsis—the bluesman through dance, the preacher through trance; both increase feelings of solidarity, boost morale, strengthen the consensus."[150] Black congregations in the industrial Northern states, in conjunction with the post-civil rights possibility of gaining middle class status, allowed for a new untapped market demographic to emerge. "To this day, Clive Davis, who was the president of CBS, claims it was his brainchild to move aggressively into Black music," critic Nelson George suggests in his book *The Death of Rhythm and Blues,* citing an inflammatory report submitted to CBS on May 11, 1972 by the Harvard University Business School titled, "A Study of the Soul Music Environment Prepared for Columbia Records Group."[151] "The growth of CBS's involvement in Black music in the years following the Harvard Report was immense," George writes. "In 1971, the CBS roster included two cutting-edge black artists, Sly and the Family Stone and Santana," but, "by 1980, it had 125 acts, among them big names like Earth, Wind and Fire, Teddy Pendergrass, the O'Jays, the Isley Brothers, and Weather Report."[152] George also directs attention to a chart in the report titled "Soul Content of Artist's Repertoire"

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contributed to a situation in which authenticity emerges among the music makers as a highly charged and bitterly contested issue." Gilroy, *The Black Atlantic*, 96.

[147] Baraka, 169.

[148] Ibid., 170-174.

[149] Keil, *Urban Blues*, 30-4.

[150] Keil, , 164

[151] Nelson George, *The Death of Rhythm and Blues* (New York: PlumeDutton Obelisk, 1988), 135. See also, Logan H. Westbrooks, *The Harvard Report*: *A Study of the Soul Music Environment Prepared for Columbia Records Group* (Los Angeles: Ascent Book Publishing, 2017).

[152] George, 136

which defines “soul” and “the soul market” using a three-category gradient of potential to reach “Almost All, Mixed, Almost None” consumer demographics. “By analyzing the total size of the record industry in 1970 ($1.66 billion), the report estimated the soul share at $120 million, or approximately 10 percent,” George surmises.[153] In his view, the historical development of Black music could be framed as a large scheme of the major recording music industry to absorb and shut out independent record labels. In his book’s introduction, George questions how Black music would be revised by the major music recording industry as a means of establishing a profitable business model from the cultural assimilation taking place in the post-Civil Rights era:

> By linking the evolution of Black radio to the growth of the independent labels, the development of retail outlets, and the structure of today's record companies, I hope both to fill a gap in the critical imagination and to tell a story that is the essence of R&B. All those factors and actors, along with performers' creativity and talent, interact to determine which artists are deemed important and which aren't—who will become today's stars, and where to look for tomorrow’s.[154]

In 1992, George coined the term “Post-Soul” in his book, *Post-Soul Nation: The Explosive, Contradictory, Triumphant, and Tragic 1980s as Experienced by African Americans (Previously Known as Blacks and Before That Negroes)* to define “the twisting, troubling, turmoil-filled, and often terrific years since the mid-seventies when Black America moved into a new phase of its history.”[155] George understood the moment of racial integration after the assassinations of Martin Luther King, Jr. and Malcolm X as “a time when America attempted to absorb the victories, failures, and ambiguities that resulted from the soul years.”[156] With the premise of preserving the oral history of Black music through the urban, social, economic, and technological advancements of the late twentieth century, Baraka penned the 1966 essay “The Changing Same (R&B and New Black Music).” In the essay's opening lines, he describes the blues as a primal Black music that contained the essence, history, and expression of culture through a continuum that developed from the call and response form of Africa and repositioned within the construct of Western instrumental ensembles. Baraka proposed that Black music, as an expression, of a nation within a nation. He writes, “Black music is African in origin, African-American in its totality, and its various forms (especially the vocal) show just how the African impulses were redistributed in its expression, and the expression itself became Christianized and post-Christianized.”

Baraka considered formalization of the African vocal tradition in the late twentieth century into rhythm and blues to be an “expression of urban and rural (in its various stylistic variations) Black America.,” He also observed that the migration from the rural South to the Northern industrial states changed the content of Black music considerably and most noticeably into a commodity that could integrate with the tastes and financial interests of the white American music recording

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[153] Ibid., 136
[154] Ibid., xiii
[155] Nelson George, *Post-Soul Nation: The Explosive, Contradictory, Triumphant, and Tragic 1980s as Experienced by African Americans (Previously Known as Blacks and Before That Negroes)* (New York: Penguin 1992), ix.
[156] George, Ibid.

industry.[157] “The R&B people left the practical God behind to slide into the slicker scene, where the dough was, and the swift folks congregated,” Amiri Baraka wrote of the changing expressions of a Black America in migration. “The new jazz people never had that practical God, as practical, and seek the mystical God both emotionally and intellectually.”[158] In the essay’s conclusion, Amiri Baraka called for a “Unity Music” that would combine the religious and secular expressions of Black Music and R&B towards a “social spiritualism” as well as an “action and reaction, a seeing, thrown in swift slick tone along the entire muscle of a people.”[159]

[157] “In urban Black popular culture, there is nothing hipper than a “con.” But it’s ironic that the practice and execution of the con is often revered as an art form in Black popular culture because Blacks and other recent arrivals to American cities were the victims of these schemes; over time, Black men and women perpetrated new and modified forms of the trade for the specific purpose of fleecing other Blacks (as well as whites). At the risk of understandment, the con game, as an income-generating activity, became an American urban cultural practice to which urban Black popular culture greatly contributed. It was also organically linked to the bourgeois, romantic vision of the city as a place filled with opportunities there for the taking as well as opportunities to take anyone who exposed their vulnerability.”
John Jeffries, “Toward a Redefinition of the Urban: The Collision of Culture,” in *Black Popular Culture, ed. Gina Dent* (Seattle: Bay Press 1992), 161.
[158] Amiri Baraka, Black Music (Brooklyn, New York, Akashic Books), 185
[159] Ibid., 203

3. The Spirit of the People is Greater than Man's Technology

"The techno-rebels have not as yet formulated a clear, comprehensive program. But if we extrapolate from their numerous manifestos, petitions, statements, and studies, we can identify several streams of thought that add up to a new way of looking at technology—a positive policy for managing the transition to a Third Wave future."
– Alvin Toffler, The Third Wave [160]

"I'd got into Alvin Toffler and his comments concerning the electronic village. I considered that there had to be more than three waves and extrapolated the necessity of interfacing the spirituality of human beings into the cybernetic matrix: between the brain, the soul and the mechanisms of cyberspace."
– Juan Atkins, liner notes, Cybotron, Interface: The Roots of Techno [161]

In December 1988, *Music Technology,* a prominent UK-based gear-oriented electronic music magazine, published an interview with Juan Atkins, introducing him as a quiet inventor whose creation had already exceeded by far what he could have ever imagined.[162] The magazine ran at a pivotal time, from 1985 to 1994, when the globalized music industry was beginning to take a leap forward into the digital age with the introduction of MIDI (Musical Instrument Digital Interface), the emergence of a new form of "additive" and "subtractive" synthesis within frequency modulation technology, and the advent of sampling—all of which would expand the horizons of possibility and accessibility for both the professional musician and the average consumer. "We watched the economics of music making turned over," *Music Technology* editor Tom Goodyer recalled in 2016. "We watched major recording studios close, and sequencers become digital audio workstations." In that time, he witnessed "the reinvention of the DJ and the ascent of dance music."[163]

The interview with Atkins was conducted by UK journalist Simon Trask, a regular contributor to *Music Technology*, whose writing over the years often veered into speculation about where this new relationship between music and technology would lead. Trask's profile was apt in its framing of Atkins as a similarly minded explorer of the future. Writing about Atkins' remix of Inner City's single "Good Life" and a remix of his own track "Techno Music" for 10 Records, Trask pinpointed the moment when techno transformed into something new and moved away from Atkins. The fact that a dance music track could top the charts at that time had opened up new territory for industry growth in electronic music. Indeed, Kevin Saunderson (as Inner City) had broadcast the techno sound into commercial success in the UK with his track "Big Fun." and "Good Life." It wasn't just one of a dozen examples of technologically innovative Black music—it was popular, topping several dance and singles charts throughout the US, UK and Europe. Trask had met with Saunderson in London, where he was recording material at Battery Studios, a few months prior; they discussed the last decade in music, but Trask's questions insinuated his underlying assumption that European techno-pop influenced the Detroit music scene.[164] Quoting one of Derrick May's many critiques of the Anglo-Saxon approach to electronic production ("English bands ten years ago hardly knew what they were doing. They left us

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[160] Alvin Toffler, *The Third Wave* (New York: Random House, 1970), 167.
[161] Juan Atkins, quoted in Jon Savage, liner notes, *Cybotron, Interface: The Roots of Techno* (Southbound, 1993).
[162] Juan Atkins, interview by Simon Trask, "Future Shock," *Music Technology* (December 1988): 38.
[163] Tom Goodyer, "Remembering *Music Technology*," introductory note to the magazine's archive on the site muzines.co.uk, March 2016, http://www.muzines.co.uk/mags/mt/active?note=1.
[164] Kevin Saunderson, interview by Simon Trask, "The Techno Wave,"*Music Technology* (September 1988): 70.

waiting. Somebody like Gary Numan started something he never concluded"[165]), Trask conceded, "many early '80s techno-pop groups have proven incapable of providing a convincing technology-driven music for the late '80s."[166]
that many of the groups to which techno music's origin had been attributed had not actually innovated much by the end of the 1980s.

"With the charts once again opening up to groups of a technological persuasion, Atkins seems set to follow in the footsteps of the early techno-pop bands he so admires,"[167] Trask wrote, beginning to make the case to *Music Technology*'s readers that they could relate to Atkins' experiments and the following expressions from Saunderson, May, and Eddie Fowlkes on the basis of their mutual love of British and European popular music. The article presumptuously notes Atkins' "enthusiasm" for Kraftwerk and Giorgio Moroder (in particular through his production work for Donna Summer) as Trask and Atkins discuss The Electrifying Mojo's introduction of electronic music to the Black community. "He played all the Parliament and Funkadelic that anybody ever wanted to hear. Those two groups were really big in Detroit at the time. In fact, they were one of the main reasons why disco didn't really grab hold in Detroit in '79,"[168] Atkins explained. Mojo's nightly tele-sonic fictions succeeded in capturing and reenvisioning how a community could experience this music in a time of economic duress, while creating a bridge from the blues and jazz of Old Hastings Street in the 1920s to the Motown "Hit Factory" of the 1960s, and through to the pre-techno progressive music of the 1970s and '80s. In essence, as Atkins saw it, Black Detroit's musical history spans much of the twentieth century as a continuous—though sometimes interrupted—train of thought.

Atkins began his first sonic experiments during the summer of 1980. His father had worked as a promoter in Detroit, booking jazz and soul musicians such as Michael Henderson and Barry White in the aftermath of the 1967 race riot and Motown Records' relocation to Los Angeles in 1972. He bought Atkins his first electric guitar for his tenth birthday; Atkins used the instrument to imitate the psychedelic effects and heavy guitar stylings of Jimi Hendrix and Sly Stone, before moving on to learn to play drums and bass guitar. Trouble in school and the kind of negative influences that a teenager can encounter in a city led Atkins to leave his mother and younger siblings in Detroit when he was fourteen to live with his grandmother in the suburban village of Belleville, thirty miles outside Detroit. In this less stimulating environment, he was able to find the time and space to process his musical inclinations: "My grandmother had a Hammond B3 organ, and we'd often go to the music shop where there was a little room with synthesizers in it. Whenever I went I'd play with them and make all these weird sounds."[169] His grandmother bought him his first electronic instrument, a Korg MS-10, an entry-level analogue synthesizer: "I messed around with that synthesizer all summer, and I'd got to the point where I was making up all sorts of drum beats on it. On the subject of equipment and workflow, the conversation between Atkins and Trask is detailed, offering a glimpse into Atkins' systems-oriented thinking. He talks about adapting a method, pioneered by Bernie Worrell of Parliament, of playing chromatic modular synthesizer bass lines on his Korg MS-10, recorded onto a Yamaha four-channel mixer with Kenwood cassette decks, which he would bounce and overdub with sounds and sequences to replicate a modest take on the sophisticated stereophonic effects that could be found in bigger budget studios. The bedroom productions that occupied much of Atkins' summer of 1980 were a perfect example of the landscape that *Music Technology* and

[165] Derrick May quoted in ibid., 72.
[166] Simon Trask, Ibid.
[167] Trask, "Future Shock," 38.
[168] Ibid., 38.
[169] Ibid., 39.

Trask's own writing anticipated in this new technological era of music making, when even a nineteen-year-old Black kid in Detroit could dream of the sounds of the future.

In autumn 1980, Atkins began attending Washtenaw Community College in Ann Arbor, MI, where he took music classes. While playing the half-dozen tracks he had compiled over the summer, Atkins attracted the ear of his classmate Richard "Rik" Davis, whom he would describe as a kind of philosopher with a very abstract style of electronic production. Sharing an interest in futurism, Atkins and Davis dove into deep conversations about Toffler's theories of industrial realism and parascientific mysticism. Davis was a loner, a twenty-eight-year-old veteran of the Vietnam War—the first American war in which Black and white soldiers were formally assigned integrated units, though instances of overt racism and white supremacist terror tactics still occurred. In a 2016 interview, Davis spoke candidly about the war, during which he caught malaria twice; he recalled how his unit was tasked with protecting the Chiêu Hồi Psychological Operations Program (PSYOP), which broadcast and distributed propaganda and American popular culture to South Vietnam: "The jungle they sent us into, even the Viet Cong wouldn't go in there. It was virgin jungle. All the Vietnamese thought we were completely nuts. There was nothing in that jungle but rock, apes and tigers. Everything in it was poisonous."[170] Being drafted into the apocalyptic scene of the war had been an escape for Davis, the population of whose hometown of Black Bottom, a predominantly Black neighborhood of Detroit, mostly found employment in the surrounding automotive and manufacturing plants. A significant musical hub in the 1950s, the area had been deemed substandard and was pushed into abject poverty by the discriminatory housing policies of the New Deal, a series of public programs, financial reforms, and regulations put in place by President Franklin D. Roosevelt in the 1930s to push towards the recovery of the United States during the Great Depression. By 1959, the 1960s, Black Bottom and Paradise Valley, an adjacent neighborhood, had been demolished as part of an urban renewal initiative pursued by the City of Detroit, and were replaced by Lafayette Park, a modernist residential district designed by architect Ludwig Mies van der Rohe.

In 1978, Davis produced and pressed the two-track, 7-inch "Methane Sea" on his own record label, Deep Sea. Titled after a highly flammable chemical compound found on the seafloor, and recorded two days after the Jonestown Massacre, Davis's sculptural sound, following on the heels of industrial blues, envisioned a devastated landscape that didn't differ very much from his own reality. "Methane Sea" portrays a fundamentally rotten atmosphere, represented by swathes of panning, multichannel granular sound, combined with Davis' affected vocals, in which he declares himself to be ethereal, infinite, and beyond the morbid constraints of the capitalist military industrial complex built up around him before he even had a chance to reach adulthood. Nearly three decades later, Davis explained that "'Methane Sea" was a meditation on some lessons from the Book of Isaiah: "I am God, there is none beside me. I am the Lord, there's no one else."[171] Attesting to his experience of the 1967 Detroit race riots as a teen and the savagery of sloppy warfare as a member of the Marines in his twenties, Davis' two five-minute sketches on "Methane Sea" contain a lifetime of emotional and experiential information. Davis spoke candidly about his difficulties reintegrating American civilian society as a veteran.[172] He returned home from Vietnam after going AWOL, and wasn't able to accept American counterculture after being exposed to the psychological warfare techniques employed by the US government during the war, as well as the rampant white supremacy of the military:

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[170] Davis, quoted in Mike Rubin, "Rik Davis: Alleys of His Mind," *Red Bull Music Academy Daily* (May 24, 2016), https://daily.redbullmusicacademy.com/2016/05/rik-davis-alleys-of-his-mind.
[171] Ibid.
[172] Ibid.

> What changed me after I got back was I saw the hippies and the Beach Boys side with their friend Charles Manson. His picture was all over the underground papers, talking about, “Charlie, he ain’t done nothing.” Later on you find out that he’s a fucking Nazi and that his whole plan was to cause a race war between Blacks and whites so that he could reign out of the bottomless pit or some such shit, but they sided with him. He’s Jesus to them, but I’m the fiend, I’m the monster.[173]

The supposed statute of equality that African Americans had obtained following the Civil Rights Act of 1964 presented a contradictory reality: in truth, the general white population seemed to hold a subconscious preoccupation with the complete annihilation of the Black race.[174] The US government limited African Americans’ access to most basic means of survival necessary within a capitalist society, while drafting more Black men into the Vietnam War than whites—enabling the domestic formation of the hippie counterculture movement. Academic Theodore Roszak documented this phenomenon in *The Making of a Counter Culture*, noting that these young white hippies were children of the technocracy, a youth generation designed by the elite class. The white youth counterculture sought liberation from the ideological confines of their urban and suburban environments and collectively rejected their responsibility, as American citizens, to fight an unjust war designed to maintain the social contract of the American Dream. Roszak referred to the African American subset of the counterculture as the “other Americans,” whose very existence asserted “a forceful, indignant campaign fixated on the issue of integrating the excluded into the general affluence.”[175] In essence, the hypocrisy of the United States that weighed on his contemporaries became for Davis a defining feature of his daily lived experience as an African American who had been funneled through too many facets of the American industrial machine within the short span of his lifetime.

Living with future shock, Davis fostered a counterculture of his own, burrowing into metaphysical philosophy, theology, and electronic music, the latter of which bears resemblance to the stereophonic stylings that had emerged through the multi-engineer studio productions of Parliament and Jimi Hendrix, as well as through jazz fusion artists like Herbie Hancock and Les McCann, and German and French *musique concrète* experiments in modified audio and tape manipulation techniques of the 1920s and ’30s. Davis’ lyrical content filtered these sonic influences through portable synthesizers in multitrack recordings, in which he evoked concepts developed from a deep trauma that surfaced as esoteric poetry stemming from numerology and referencing the writings of H.P. Lovecraft, and Biblical scripture. The literary and imagistic elements of Davis’ approach to electronic music, both under his own name and under the pseudonym 3070, shouldered the burden of proving that sound can do more than simply be heard, given how much emotion and historical material he managed to pack into the 7-inch—a very human factor that is often overlooked in favor of a fascination with the computational and probable outcomes of electronic instruments.

“He had an ARP Odyssey, ARP Axxe, Roland RS09 string machine, the ARP analogue sequencer and an early Roland sequencer, and the Boss DR55 Dr Rhythm. I had my little Korg

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[173] Ibid.

[174] “It would have made sense at the close of the Civil War to plan for the assimilation of Black people as a group into the American mainstream. Racism made this impossible. Now, as racism begins to crumble, the requirements of an advanced technological economy increasingly exclude Black workers from the active labor force. Hence racism, the stepchild of slavery, prevented Black people from following in the footsteps of other ethnic groups.” Robert L. Allen, *Black Awakening in Capitalist America: An Analytical History* (Trenton, NJ: Africa World Press, 1992), 51.

[175] Theodore Roszak, *The Making of a Counter Culture: Reflections on the Technocratic Society and Its Youthful Opposition* (Garden City, NY: Anchor Books, 1969), 13.

MS10," Atkins recounted. He was "blown away" by Davis' home studio.[176] "It was during the day, but it was dark—the blinds were closed. The only lights you could see were coming from the keyboards. It wasn't really consumer gear—the stuff you could see anywhere. They had these LEDs. It looked like an airplane cockpit."[177] The meeting of Atkins and Davis was kismet, an opportunity to merge their isolated worlds and bridge a generational gap. At first, wanting to maintain his privacy, Davis chose not to meet at his home, which Atkins attributed to the assumption that collaborative music projects require multiple people—consider the number of large ensemble groups common to the funk and soul genres. But what Atkins was looking for was a distilled sound, using the electronic equipment to cover more ground with less manpower—a lean, homemade production model scaled from the industrial processes pioneered in Detroit auto factories. Over time, their conversations began to reshape into a new manner of speaking, eventually producing a techno-futurist dictionary and imagined virtual environment called "The Grid." "This was a time when the video-game phenomenon was coming in," Atkins explained later. "We used a lot of video terms to refer to real-life situations. We conceived of the streets or the environment as being like the Game Grid. And Cybotron was considered a 'super-sprite.' Certain images in a video programme are referred to as 'sprites,' and a super sprite had certain powers on the game-grid that a regular sprite didn't have."[178] The synthesis and creation of new terms was as central to Atkins and Davis' collaboration as was sonic experimentation, which they cemented by adopting the name Cybotron—a portmanteau Atkins made up by combining the words "cyborg" and "cyclotron," a particle accelerator invented by American nuclear scientist Ernest O. Lawrence in 1930.[179] During this process of creation, Davis shared with Atkins the music he'd gathered while on active duty abroad, encouraging him to take notice of European electronic musicians like Kraftwerk. Until then, Atkins had been unaware of canonical examples of synthesizer music beyond Bernie Worrell, and this encouraged him to pursue and refine his specific idea of techno music. He told Trask that he respected the musical contributions of Kraftwerk, Devo, etc.—"but they weren't funky."[180] The sense-altering extra musical effects of funk music—the point at which sounds seem to shift beyond perceptibility, levitate, and protrude from the speakers—were more interesting to Atkins: "I felt that if I could take that type of music and add a funky element to it then it would be a smash. We did that, but we just didn't get recognized. Soul Sonic Force came along and beat us to it."[181] In 1981, Cybotron established their own label, Deep Space, and produced the track "Alleys of Your Mind," which could figuratively be called the first techno track.

As the story goes, Atkins passed along a demo of the single to sixteen-year-old Derrick May, who lived near the WGPR studio where The Electrifying Mojo broadcast his nightly show. May decided that he would get his friend's music on the radio. He played the alien-invasion shooter game Defender at the café where Mojo was known to go after his show, finally managing to intercept Mojo and convincing him to play "Alleys of Your Mind" on his next show. Davis' music had already gotten considerable airplay on The Electrifying Mojo's show: "Methane Sea" served as its theme. Cybotron's first single was a winning combination of optimized funk that would gain them considerable popularity in Detroit. Looking back on this moment in 1988, Atkins told Trask

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[176] Atkins, in Trask, "Future Shock," 9.
[177] Juan Atkins, interview with Dave Tompkins, "The Things They Buried: On Cybotron's Embattled Techno Sci-Fi Masterpiece, 'Enter,'" *SPIN* (October 30, 2013), https://www.spin.com/2013/10/cybotron-clear-reissue-dave-tompkins-sci-fi-techno/.
[178] Juan Atkins, quoted in Simon Reynolds, *Generation Ecstasy: Into the World of Techno and Rave Culture* [1999] (London: Routledge, 2016), 18.
[179] Earnest O. Lawrence and Stanley M. Livingston, M. Stanley, "The Production of High Speed Light Ions Without the Use of High Voltages," *Physical Review* 40, no. 1 (April 1, 1932): 19–35.
[180] Atkins, in Trask, "Future Shock," 39.
[181] Ibid.

about the early misreadings of his and Davis's electronic funk, even as it gained substantial popularity for an independent release: "I had people come up to me and say they thought Cybotron was some white guys from Europe. People couldn't believe we were actually Detroit musicians. We sold between 7,000 and 10,000 copies of that record in Detroit."[182] The shuffled beat and claps provided by Atkins contrasted with Davis' phaser-like ARP melodies on "Alleys of Your Mind." The B-side "Cosmic Raindance" proposed an imaginary soundtrack to Samuel R. Delany's *Dhalgren* (1975), a science-fiction novel about a ruinous city in the American Midwest isolated from the outside world by technological failure, the natural intrusion of storm cloud coverage, and the psychological dissolution of the city's inhabitants. Delany's writing verges into the delirium of modernity and its rule-bound excesses in a way that offers a glimpse into what Davis and Atkins were trying to produce with their music.[183] "Where is your sense of time?," Atkins mutters, his vocals buried in a prismatic mix of staunch percussion, while soft, pointed synth keystrokes punctuate Cybotron's conception that this funk of the future, this techno music, could "Pop your mind at the seams."[184] From the depths of the self to the environment of the other, "Cosmic Raindance" expands the vision of "Alleys of Your Mind" into a pointillist, multi-channel jam, utilizing overdubbing to layer and delay sounds, to surround the listener.

Cybotron's second single was released the next year, in 1982, as Detroit hosted its first Grand Prix Formula One automotive race. "Cosmic Car" saw Atkins and Davis hone in on the macrostructures brought about by urban renewal, including what Toffler called the "tools of tomorrow." Based on Atkins' own car—a 1980 Oldsmobile Cutlass—"Cosmic Car" envisions a sonic interpretation of the sensation of machine-produced acceleration. "Stepping on the gas. Driving alone," intone the lyrics. A metronome locks into place several multi-track and delayed drum patterns. "All I see are stars, and other cosmic cars." Atkins and Davis' world pulses with information and increasingly updates its ability to activate the listeners' senses, while psychologically attuning them to the pace of life in their own industrial future. Toffler referred to a kind of "break with the past" as a feature of future shock. For Atkins and Davis, as African Americans, the transition into the future was something worth exploring in and of itself. Similar to "culture shock," in which a stranger enters a new society and experiences emotional distress and mental resistance in response to the change of environment, "future shock" describes the barrier of entry that Atkins and Davis' were crossing with their musical experiments.[185]

Eventually a third member, John "Jon-5" Housely, joined Cybotron, occasionally on guitar, which centered the group's sound and situated the band between sonic futures in electronic funk and progressive rock, rhythm and soul. "The Line," the B-side of their single, imprints the very modern scenario of rationing moments of one's life while waiting for the next consumable event. "Life is a line, just take your place," Davis sings in the New-Wave-style chorus, over Jon-5's pensive guitar and Atkins' drum and bass couplets. A consistent four-over-four, four-on-the-floor pulse slowly accelerates the song through arpeggiated and pitched keyboards, displaying a sense of linearity as it follows a more classic verse-chorus-verse-bridge-chorus format, addressing concerns similar to Toffler's own thoughts on the "duration of expectancy."[186] One's perception of time is undoubtedly altered as the surrounding environment is optimized, while

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[182] Ibid.
[183] "But I realized something. About art. And psychiatry. They're both self-perpetuating systems. Like religion. All three of them promise you a sense of inner worth and meaning, and spend a lot of time telling you about the suffering you have to go through to achieve it." Samuel R. Delany, *Dhalgren* (New York: Bantam Books, 1975), 334.
[184] Cybotron, lyrics to "Alleys of Your Mind," on *Alleys of Your Mind* (Deep Space, 1981).
[185] Alvin Toffler, *Future Shock* (New York: Random House, 1970), 4.
[186] Ibid., 40.

one's experience of time is compressed. In their productions, Atkins and Davis sought to create their own version of the future.

"Cosmic Cars" was a commercial success, selling around 15,000 copies and even reaching the ears of Fantasy Records, an independent record label in San Francisco founded in 1949 by brothers Max and Sol Weiss, known for releasing records by jazz pianist Dave Brubeck, Chet Baker, and Beat poet Allen Ginsburg. Rather than "discovering" Cybotron through the conventional method of sending a scouting agent to observe acts before they gain an audience, the Weiss brothers decided to send a contract in the mail—a straightforward measure to catch and ride the initial wave of a rising phenomenon of electronic sound homegrown by the African American youth counterculture. Having signed and released tracks by disco vocalist and "male diva" Sylvester in the late '70s, Fantasy had already put their support behind initial sounds of the Hi-NRG movement that had taken shape in the '80s queer San Francisco scene. In 1983, Atkins, Davis, and Jon-5 were set to release their debut album *Enter,* leading with the single "Clear."

Beginning with a mic check, Cybotron's latest upgrade was designed to be a palette cleanser. Paring down the sound of their rock-oriented music, "Clear" was a leaner production, recalling Atkins and Davis's earlier works together: it takes a single word and spirals into the tangible possibilities of the word's meaning. Like in Davis' solo works, "Clear" represents an unpeopled city mired in destruction, but in contrast, as Atkins once noted, "Clear" concluded with an optimistic statement: "Out with the old / In with the new." This closing line was ultimately edited out of the radio version, in which the vocals invoke Toffler's understanding of America as a "throw-away society." In the depths of the song, "Clear" makes a provocative claim about the military industrial complex, as well as the United States' position as both an empire that had "cleared" the land and native people to establish itself, and a monstrous force that "clears" other populations in a self-determined rapture. The biblical deterrents found in the Book of Revelations in part inspired Davis to consider where he himself was located in the cycle of human civilization. His experiences of the backend of the United States, acquired through his military service, soured Atkins' more hopeful view of the future and its potential. Where Davis saw inevitability and conceit, Atkins saw revolution and opportunity. This undoubtedly began to test their working relationship, as well as call into question whether or not Cybotron's shared vision of the future was a utopia or a dystopia. In 2013, thirty years after its initial release, Fantasy reissued Cybotron's "Clear" and connected Davis with journalist Dave Tompkins to discuss the album:

> Embrace the world-destroyer. It's the only way to live. Because whatever you cling to, it'll be destroyed. The hippies perished in it. They thought it was forever. When you go away into something like [Vietnam] and come back, you find that everything has been destroyed. Your youth is gone. There's no place for you. Everybody has moved on. The pain is terrific. Nobody wanted to be bothered with us. When you come back, you're out of style.[187]

Their latest experiment in electronic funk was another hit release for the band, reaching number 52 on the Billboard Black Singles chart and amassing a significant African American audience. With a record deal and popular album under their belt, Atkins and Davis struggled to compromise on whether they wanted to move forward as a rock band or an electronic act. Davis feared ceding autonomy to the future and its technologies, whereas Atkins wanted to dive further into the potentials of electronic instrumentation; effectively, the two techno-rebels were at

[187] Rik Davis, quoted in Tompkins, "The Things They Buried."

an ideological crossroads between man and machine. Their response to the popularity of "Clear" was an inviting ballad called "Techno City," released in 1984. Marked with a decidedly chrome finish, the song is a sonic fiction about being born and raised in a city designed for technical workers; this resonated with listeners around the world who were also hoping to rethink their urban surroundings and leap into the future.[188] "We hope you enjoy your stay," Davis warns with a breathy vocal, "you'll never want to go away." "Techno City" broadened their environment of imaginary, interpretive objects and places beyond the superimposition of the self in "Alleys of Your Mind."; in "Cosmic Car," Cybotron harped on the promise of the freedom of automotive mobility; and concluded with "Techno City," the portrait of a pious civilization erected to nominally house these imagined objects and scenarios. Having condensed the Motown studio production engineering model down to a small group of technologically enhanced multi-instrumentals, Cybotron achieved what Atkins and Davis had set out to do as techno-rebels: to explore the futurity of their own sonic fictional world.[189]

Meanwhile, Detroit's economy was in a freefall caused by the slowing of automotive production that resulted from the Reaganomic principle of instrumentalizing complex, abstract indicators of the data-driven stock market. But the Black counterculture movement continued to grow alongside the commercial success of Cybotron's techno funk sound, even as the city became overwhelmed with crime and poverty. To quote "Industrial Lies" (on the album of the same title, 1983), Cybotron's response to the conservative political economics of the early '80s Reagan Revolution: "Well, it's just industrial lies hidden behind your eyes / Maximize, profitize exploitation / Take what you want and leave the rest behind." Appealing to speculative economics, the United States government abandoned the industrial systems that had supported American families, in the process excluding the Black families that had migrated northward in the 1940s. In the 1980s, white middle-class, white-collar workers flocked from cities enduring the harsh hit of a recession to the suburban outskirts. Taking advice from a friend, May's mother moved from the city of Detroit to the suburban town of Belleville to shorten her commute to work and gain access to a good (and predominantly white) school system and environment. "I lived in the city until I was 13, then we went out to the suburbs for three or four years before moving back," May recalled in a 2004 interview.[190] For May, those four years spent out of the city were the most defining years of his life.

"We weren't from small town Belleville. We moved to Belleville, all for different reasons," May mused on the disrupted family structures that he, Atkins, and Saunderson were all raised in. "Kevin's mom had her response for getting her home out there. She had two kids, Kevin and his sister. Juan's father had his reasons. He had two brothers, so... Various reasons, but it's funny

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[188] "'Techno City' was the electronic village. It was divided into different sectors. I'd watched Fritz Lang's Metropolis which had privileged sectors in the clouds and the underground worker's city. I thought there should be three sectors: the idea was that a person could be born and raised in Techno City—the worker's city—but what he wanted to do was work his way to the cybodrome where artists and intellectuals reside. There would be no Morloch, but all sorts of diversions, games, electronic instruments. Techno City was the equivalent of the ghetto in Detroit: on Woodward Avenue the pimps, pushers, etc. get overlooked by the Renaissance Tower." Richard "Rik" Davis, quoted in Savage, liner notes, *Cybotron, Interface* (1994).

[189] "Cybotron's *Techno City*, like all these possibility spaces, is Sonic Fiction: electronic fiction, with frequencies fictionalized, synthesized and organized into escape routes. Sonic Fiction replaces lyrics with possibility spaces, with a plan for getting out of jail free. Escapism is organized until it seizes the means of perception and multiplies the modes of sensory reality."
Kodwo Eshun, "More Brilliant Than the Sun," 103

[190] Derrick May, interview by Bill Brewster and Frank Broughton, originally published on DJhistory.com, August 2004, republished in *Red Bull Music Academy Daily*, May 22, 2017, https://daily.redbullmusicacademy.com/2017/05/interview-derrick-may.

because it brought us all together."[191] May recalled that the sonic fiction of Detroit techno began during a period of isolation, away from the city, in part because of its financial collapse. With only vague memories of what a functioning, bustling Detroit looked like, through the patchy filter of childhood memories, May developed a fascination with an idea of the future placed firmly in the historical past. Though a decade had passed since the long, hot summer of race-related riots scorched the nation—and specifically Detroit—May remembered his first few days of high school as a crash course on the passive-aggressive, semi-subconscious behavioral coordination and control mechanisms developed and employed by suburban white people fearing that their close-minded way of living within a planned environment would be altered by the presence of difference. Having spent most of the summer getting to know the white kids in his apartment complex, May was unfortunate enough to have believed that he had formed a community with the children of white families who had fled the failed racial integration project of the city of Detroit. "When we went to school the first day, I'll never forget it," May recalled:

> Troy was the kid's name. He was my best buddy all summer. After waiting in line to get his lunch, he went and just sat down at the first table. I was right behind him, so when I got my lunch I went and sat down with Troy. I'll never forget it, because all of the white kids at the table looked at me. They gave me this really strange look. Troy didn't notice it and I didn't really pay much attention to it, either. I had not been subjected to any kind of racism before. I think the city kids live a kind of protected life in a sense. If you live in a predominantly white or Black area in the city, you don't ever come into contact with certain elements. You think you're rough and tough, you're schooled and seasoned, but you're not really, because you've never been subjected to the oneness, you know. So I noticed it, but Troy didn't. Then a kid came up, a Black kid, and he looked at me and said, "Hey man, why you sitting up here with all the honkies?" I looked at him and I said, "The honkies?" It hadn't even dawned on me that I was sitting with a bunch of white kids. It never occurred to me. And then one of the schoolteachers came up to me and said, "You should be sitting back there."[192]

May would then experience the social phenomenon of voluntarily segregated lunchrooms at supposedly integrated schools like Belleville High School. "I pitied these people," May continued. "There were about 40 tables in this lunchroom and this was basically the whole Black population of kids going to school there. The other 40 tables were all full of white kids."[193] The culture shock stayed with May, who felt himself to be more well-mannered than the rest of the Black kids who had also been uprooted from their homes to the less stimulating and controlled environment of the suburbs, governed by white, small-town logistics. "I used to look left at the table just across from me, a table that was all white kids, and observe how they used to look over at these Black people who acted like fucking animals. These Black kids were all from West Willow, from what had once been well-to-do decent families who had migrated from the South a couple of generations ago. Proud people who no longer had a job."[194] The United States as a whole was going through a large-scale identity crisis and transformation that American historian Nell Painter refers to as a series of enlargements of whiteness as a race category for American landowning and indentured working-class citizens who could visibly pass as white, in direct opposition to the existentially Black population comprised of the African American former slave class. Painter writes that, "The civil rights movement, it seemed, had spawned the ugly specter

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[191] Ibid.
[192] Ibid.
[193] Ibid.
[194] Ibid.

of Black power, a source of alienation for white people"—"white versus Black," she summarizes, "now sufficed as an American racial scheme."[195]

Like May, Saunderson was having a hard time adjusting to the planned environment of suburban housing and retail developments, explaining in 2018:

> When I moved to Belleville, I moved into a nice, I guess middle class neighborhood around lakes and stuff like that and it might have been three or four black families that lived in that whole kind of... They called it a subdivision. So it's might be, I don't know, 150 houses, whatever. I used to always wake up, I'm doing whatever, I look outside and I see all this trash in my yard. I'm like, "Well, how'd that get there?" But it was continuously. So one day, I was outside and I heard... You see cars go by, whatever, and these cars go by and they say... they blurt out these words like, "N---a, n---a, n---a." And I'm like... I don't really know. I didn't know at that time what racism was, I didn't know what the word meant. But I watched this movie called Roots and that's when I got my first education about slavery, and then about racism, and then I put two and two together and I could tell that these people didn't want me in this neighborhood. When I first moved into Belleville, the first whatever, first month, two months, that's what I got when I first moved there.[196]

Saunderson met May around this time, when they were fourteen, during an altercation that resulted in him punching May and giving him a concussion; the two subsequently became close friends. May met thirteen-year-old Aaron Atkins, Juan Atkins' brother, at a table in the front of the cafeteria before they were both invited to sit with the Black kids. "It was a culture shock for me. It blew me away. I had never experienced, like… voluntary segregation," May remembered. "I think that changed me. That was a defining moment in my life, because it put me… it made me feel outside who I thought I was."[197] One day, Aaron Atkins took May with him on a drive in his Fleetwood Cadillac with crushed-velvet seats. "Aaron was chillin' man! He had the Funkadelic pumpin' through the soundsystem, and I was like, 'What is that?' And that's what changed my life."[198] May reminisced about hearing Parliament's "Mr. Funkenstein" (1976), the first moment he felt the pulse of hi-tech music and its sense-altering effects within an urban and suburban reality: "That shit just blew me away. I was outside playing with my two buddies, Tom and Jerry—those were genuinely their names—and Aaron pulled up with the gangster lean and the George Clinton and Funkadelic pumpin' out of the car. I was like, 'Wow. This music, this car, this thing, this guy!' He took me for a ride and it changed my life. It was another defining moment."[199]

May, Atkins, and Saunderson would eventually find each other and begin to exchange music and other interests. Describing Atkins as an introvert with permed hair who constantly practiced on his bass guitar, May noted that it had taken him a while to gain his trust: "I'm looking at this dude, he looks at me and he instantly doesn't like me because I'm a square. I'm a complete square for these guys. I mean, these guys come from Detroit, the other side of town. They've come up another way and have another lifestyle."[200] They ultimately connected when May

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[195] Nell Irvin Painter, *The History of White People* (New York: W. W. Norton & Company, 2011), 382.
[196] Kevin Saunderson, interview by Christine Kakaire at the Red Bull Music Academy, Berlin, 2018, https://www.redbullmusicacademy.com/lectures/kevin-saunderson.
[197] May, in Brewster and Broughton interview.
[198] Ibid.
[199] Ibid.
[200] Ibid.

challenged Atkins to a game of chess. By this point, May's mother had moved the family back to Detroit, letting him finish the school year in Belleville, where he moved in with Saunderson's family. One day, May decided to listen to a blank cassette tape that he had left behind at Atkins' house. "I felt like the tape was valuable, so after some weeks I said, 'Can I have my tape back?' Juan said to me, 'Listen man, to be honest with you there's some shit on the tape you're not gonna like. Let me just give you another tape for that tape, because you ain't gonna like what's on the tape.' But I said, 'No, give it back to me! I want my tape.'"[201] So May played the tape. "We were just chillin', listening. What was on the tape? Giorgio Moroder, some early Tangerine Dream shit, that kind of thing. It was completely psychedelic. It was another digestive lesson I was being given. This time it wasn't just for me, but also for Kevin. I had some familiarity with some of the stuff because I'd been round Juan's house, but it was the first time Kevin had heard this music. It freaked him out."[202] May never gave Atkins that tape back, but he did start listening to The Electrifying Mojo with Saunderson, and a true friendship started to develop between May and Atkins over their shared interest in the possibilities of electronic music.

Forming the Deep Space collective a few months later, the trio set out to make a name for themselves in Detroit's progressive music scene, alongside other DJs like Jeff Mills and Mike "Agent X" Clark. In time, May moved in with Atkins in Detroit, and they lost touch with Saunderson, who was still living in Belleville. "There was this period where it was just myself and Juan again," May mused. "Music was becoming our common denominator. We would just sit in his bedroom and analyze records." After the initial success of Cybotron, May described Atkins as feeling like he had lost his footing after leaving the band: "There was no help in sight, he had this creative, brilliant idea and there was nobody out there to share it with. He thought that nobody would ever understand him."[203] While visiting his mother in Chicago, May heard "Feel the Drive," an imported Italo disco song by the group Doctor's Cat, on the radio, which increased his confidence in the electronic sounds that he and Atkins had been developing throughout their high school years. Released in 1983, the same year as Cybotron's debut album, "Feel the Drive" was popularized amongst the Chicago and Detroit dance music circles by producer and DJ Frankie Knuckles, who frequently played it during his sets at the Power Plant, a popular club he opened in Chicago in 1982. After calling around, May visited Importes, Etc., an infamous Chicago record store frequented by DJs looking for vinyl to play in their sets, known for almost exclusively selling dance music. After hearing Frankie Knuckles' DJ sets on Hot Mix 5, May set out to find the developing house music scene. This assured him that Atkins wasn't alone in his technological explorations, and that there was something brewing in the twin urban centers. Chicago, like Detroit, had experienced a significant influx of Black people from the South, which led to a mass white flight to the suburbs. Unlike Detroit, the city of Chicago wasn't inherited by the Black population; instead, implementing discriminatory home-loan discrimination against Black people in industrial real-estate process called redlining and blockbusting that created a concentrated Black minority culture and demographic.

Scaling down further to an even leaner product, Atkins would take the name Model 500 after departing from Cybotron, which went on to release two albums for Fantasy Records (*Empathy* in 1993 and *Cyber Ghetto* in 1995). In the *Music Technology* interview, Trask inquired into the project name's, assuming that it bore a direct relation to the Ford Model-T, the first affordable automobile built on an assembly line.[204] "It has nothing to do with Ford," Atkins initially refuted, stating instead that the name placed him in the tradition of the work he had begun with Davis,

[201] Ibid.
[202] Ibid.
[203] Ibid.
[204] Atkins, in Trask, "Future Shock," 39.

which explored technology as a modifying, neutralizing instrument. “I wanted to use something that repudiated an ethnic designation, something that was really techno ‘cos I’ve always been into a techno/futurist thing. We always used numbers and computer phrases, like Jon5, 3070, Enter, Clear.”[205] Now on his own, Atkins was able to think and compose broadly according to his own vision of the future, starting his label and built environment, Metroplex.[206] The first song to come from his new project was originally meant for Cybotron, but had been refashioned into an isolated meditation on the limits of what can be known about the cosmos and who can inhabit it. In “No UFOs” and its B-Side “Future,” released in 1985, he distilled the electronic funk sound that he had developed even further, both musically and lyrically. A possible holdover from the influence of Davis, who expressed apprehension towards the government and public relations, Atkins’ “No UFOs” questioned the possibility of thought control and a programmable society: the song plays out a scenario in which Atkins speaks directly to the hypothetical scenario of intelligent extraterrestrials arriving to Earth in unidentified flying objects (UFOs).[207] Though his lyrics start with phrases like “I hope they don’t catch us, analyze and test us,” they end with a surly, sanguine outlook: “If we get together. Cut out all the game, maybe catch our tempers, maybe act more tame. Put down all our weapons. Strange as it may seem, then maybe we can travel beyond our wildest dreams.”

Selling upwards of 15,000 copies, Atkins’ first experiment with a one-man music production model under the alias Model 500 and his own Metroplex record label were becoming increasingly profitable. As with his first single with Cybotron, May, who split his time between the twin cities, was on the ground distributing copies of “No UFOs” directly to record shops, consumers, and local DJs. The momentum that “Clear” had initiated in the Black youth culture in 1983 had gained speed following the formation of Deep Space. “At that time you could get records that were just rhythm tracks of popular songs, and it had become popular for these rhythm tracks to be spun in between other records,” explained Atkins, discussing how techno made its way into the public domain three years earlier. “As I was already making my own music, I had the idea that Derrick and me could bring a drum machine into a party for mixing in between records.”[208] A kind of urban arms race for electronic instruments and innovative ways of using them was becoming a cultural norm and mode of expression for African American youth in the city and suburbs: “We unveiled our secret weapon, which was that we’d brought a Roland 808 to the party to play live rhythm tracks between the records.”[209] Atkins’ sound developed while taking an audio engineering course at the Recording Institute of Detroit, where he acquired a preference for gear with the most electronic sounds and feel, as opposed to “digitally-sampled real drums.” “When Roland discontinued the 808 and 909 to come out with

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[205] Ibid.

[206] “Simulations are the real-world activations of data to calculate and predict future action and movement: how a star will explode, how a hurricane will move. They are both literal products of equations that describe what actions can happen inside of a virtual world, and potent metaphors for future-casting. We *simulate* when we imagine ourselves and others in the future, and we base our current actions on that mental simulation.”
Nora Khan, “Seeing, Naming, Knowing,” Brooklyn Rail, 2019,
https://brooklynrail.org/2019/03/art/Seeing-Naming-Knowing

[207] “The notion that unidentified flying objects (UFOs) belong to extraterrestrial life or non-human aliens from other planets occupying physical spacecraft visiting Earth, is known as the extraterrestrial hypothesis (ETH). It can be traced back to a number of earlier ideas, starting with Emanuel Swedenborg, who in *The Earths in the Universe* stated that he conversed with spirits Jupiter, Mars, Mercury, Saturn, Venus, the Moon, as well as spirits from planets beyond our solar system, describing them as human-like but immaterial beings who communicated telepathically.”
David Livingstone, “The UFO Phenomenon,” in *Black Terror White Soldiers: Islam, Fascism, and the New Age* (n.p.: Sabilillah Publications, 2013), 361.

[208] Atkins, in Trask, “Future Shock,” 42.

[209] Ibid.

the 707 and 505," he noted, "they tried to come out with a more true drum sound, but the whole beauty of Roland was that they had drum sounds which were different from everybody else's."[210] Atkins was looking for sounds native to the machine, and injecting soul and feeling directly into the interface. Because of his preference for older, outmoded drum machines, Model 500 was able to produce and maintain a singular and technically unreplicable sound.

Trask relates Atkins' insular and independently released electronic music to the big budget success of Jimmy Jam and Terry Lewis, whose techno-adjacent productions on Janet Jackson's *Control* won him the Grammy Award for "Producer of the Year" in 1987, a year before *Techno!* hit the shelves. Humble and self-assured, Atkins replies, "A lot of things have been happening in Detroit for a long time now, and it's all starting to come to the forefront." In his book *Techno Rebels*, journalist Dan Sicko commented, nearly a decade later, "As far as I know, nobody had applied technology to music using that term ["techno"], especially in dance music. You had electronic musicians out there, but most of them were really abstract. Nobody's claiming that we invented electronic music."[211] Distancing himself from the public and media perception of techno as a generalized form of dance music, Atkins acknowledged that "some people" would "get all bent out of shape" over the assertion that he invented dance music, but assured that "Techno is something that just happened. People looked at you like you have some big, preconceived plan, [but] it's the general public who designated us to be who we are."[212]

Atkins' electronic funk resonated within the Chicago club circuit that included May and his roommate Eddie Fowlkes, who would eventually upgrade to DJing hybrid live sets with three turntables, a mixer, and guitar effect pedals with drum machines. Fowlkes had first visited Chicago in 1981 with Detroit DJ Ken Collier and a group of people from the local progressive music scene. Arriving at the Warehouse club at 2am, they witnessed Frankie Knuckles mixing his own edits of classic Philly International tracks and European imports on a reel-to-reel tape machine. "That was an experience!" Fowlkes declared. "Chicago had the best parties. Hands down."[213] As word spread, Blake Baxter, a musician . . . , then enlisted in the US special operations forces, drove the four hours from Detroit to Chicago himself in 1986. "Detroit people drove to Chicago all the time," remembered Fowlkes. "Everyone from K. Hand to Derrick May was going because Chicago had the best clubs and a good underground scene."[214] Once there, Baxter met the owner of D.J, International Records, who asked him to record a demo at a local studio, where he connected with Chicago musicians Marshall Jefferson, Joe Smooth, Chip-E, and Tyree Cooper, as well as May, while recording keyboard and vocals over an affordable Juno 60. "At that time I was strictly a drummer in calypso bands doing studio session stuff," Baxter noted; he hadn't yet gotten access to a drum machine, and was recording "some drums on electronic drum pads."[215]

Atkins claimed to have bought "the first 808 in Michigan" while still in high school: "I had a class called Future Studies, about the transition from an industrial society to a technological society. I just applied a lot of those principles to my music-making."[216] Fowlkes remembers Atkins

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[210] Ibid.
[211] Sicko, *Techno Rebels*, 102.
[212] Atkins, quoted in ibid., 70–71.
[213] Eddie Fowlkes, quoted in Heiko Hoffmann, "From the Autobahn to I-94," *Pitchfork*, November 28, 2005, https://pitchfork.com/features/article/6204-from-the-autobahn-to-i-94/.
[214] Ibid.
[215] Baxter, quoted in ibid.
[216] "The 808 allowed you to actually build your own patterns—you were able to put the kick drums and snares where you wanted them. It opened up a lot of creativity." Juan Atkins, quoted in Ben Beaumont-Thomas, "The Roland

introducing the 808 in 1984: “At one point we stopped the turntables and Juan would start to work on his 808. He would start switching that shit and motherfuckers just went nuts. The next thing you saw was Jeff Mills using an 808 and all of a sudden every DJ had a drum machine.”[217] In the 2006 documentary *High Tech Soul*, Fowlkes divulged what he jokingly called “the true story” of how drum machines permeated inner city Detroit: Atkins’ brother-in-law briefly moved in after being released from prison and as a token of his gratitude, shared a “credit card scam tip” with Fowlkes and May. “We started ordering equipment, everything, all types of shit!“ Fowlkes said.[218] But regardless of the origins of its initiation, the Chicago house scene began to catch onto the possibilities of the 808 rhythm composer through May and Fowlkes. “Derrick sold Chicago DJ Frankie Knuckles a TR-909 drum machine,” Atkins recalled. “This was back when the Powerplant was open in Chicago, but before any of the Chicago DJs were making records. They were all into playing Italian imports; ‘No UFOs’ was the only US-based independent record that they played.”[219] In a 2005 interview, Atkins recounted that “Derrick was going to Chicago and they tried to call our music the house sound of Detroit. In Chicago, you had the Jesse Saunders stuff and the Jamie Principle stuff and titles like ‘acid house’[220] or something like that. But that was Techno! They just didn't call it that because it would give Detroit too much influence.”[221] “Juan was very protective of his sound and Derrick didn’t understand this,” Fowlkes noted, but the transmission had occurred: “That’s how the 909 sound came to Chicago,” he continued. “This is how the sound between Detroit and Chicago merged.”[222]

TR-808: the drum machine that revolutionised music,” *The Guardian* (March 6, 2014), https://www.theguardian.com/music/2014/mar/06/roland-tr-808-drum-machine-revolutionised-music

[217] Fowlkes, quoted in Hoffmann, “From the Autobahn to I-94.”

[218] Fowlkes, in *High Tech Soul: The Creation of Techno Music*, directed by Gary Bredow (Plexifilm, 2006).

[219] Atkins, in Trask, “Future Shock,” 42.

[220] Juan Atkins didn’t use a Roland TB-303 “because the idea is to take things that exist, mix them with your own ideas and create something totally new. I didn't want to sound exactly like everybody else out there, but I like the acid feel and I like the reason why acid is out there, because it enabled me to step out a little bit. What I get people telling me now is that I sound like a new acid. It really makes me feel good that people are noticing the difference between techno and acid, not just slapping us in the same category and saying that when acid music dies techno will die too 'cos it's all the same. A lot of things have been happening in Detroit for a long time now, and it's all starting to come to the forefront. It's a shame for America that the music's happening first in the UK as opposed to there, though.” Atkins, in Trask, “Future Shock,” 43.

[221] Atkins, quoted in Hoffman, “From the Autobahn to I-94.”

[222] Fowlkes, in ibid.